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BRICS SUMMIT
12 - 13 September 2026
New Delhi, India

BUILDING FOR RESILIENCE, INNOVATION,
COOPERATION AND SUSTAINABILITY

**People-Centric
Approach
Spirit of
Humanity First**



CBC 14129/13/0020/2627

SC may widen its scrutiny of buildings to cover PGs

Utkarsh Anand

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday indicated it may expand its court-monitored exercise against illegal constructions and unauthorised change of land use in Delhi to cover the safety of student accommodation, following the death of seven people in the collapse of an illegally constructed building being used as a paying guest facility in Satya Niketan.

A bench of justices Ahsanuddin Amanullah and R Mahadevan said it would urgently take up the issue on Thursday, after the amicus curiae sought an expansion of the ongoing inspection exercise to PG accommodations, private hostels and similar facilities around colleges and universities across Delhi.

The court turned down an oral request from Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre, MCD and Delhi Police, to allow the Delhi High Court to continue dealing with the Satya Niketan collapse separately.

When Mehta urged that the tragic incident not be mixed with the larger issue already pending before the Supreme

continued on →9



Temporary support beams being installed in a building in Satya Niketan on Tuesday. SANCHIT KHANNA/HT

REGULATORY AMNESTIES SHIELD ILLEGAL FLOORS

The crackdown on illegal fifth floors in the city announced by Delhi chief minister Rekha Gupta after the Satya Niketan building collapse faces significant hurdles from regulatory amnesties, including an act of Parliament that has been periodically updated since 2006 and the recent regularisation of 1,511 unauthorised colonies. Civic

officials said that successive governments had introduced regularisation schemes, amnesty provisions and special laws that allowed unauthorised settlements and illegal constructions to remain unscathed, in part, because taking action against the multitude of such properties in Delhi was politically challenging.

BUILDING LEASED BY 2 BIZ PARTNERS: PROBE

A labour contractor was held from Uttar Pradesh on Tuesday in connection with the Satya Niketan collapse, even as the Delhi Police investigation found that the five-storey building was being operated by two business partners who had taken the property on lease in August 2025 and are absconding.

Russia says Brics can bridge Iran-UAE gap

Rezaul H Laskar

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NEW DELHI: Russia remains hopeful that Brics member states will be able to bridge differences between Iran and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) over the West Asia conflict and achieve consensus in framing joint documents for the grouping's summit to be hosted by India over the weekend, a key aide to Russian President Vladimir Putin said on Tuesday.

The Brics Summit to be held during September 12-13 will focus on cooperation across the three pillars of politics and security, economy and finance, and cultural and humanitarian contacts, Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov said while addressing a virtual media briefing from Moscow. Joint



NSG commandos conduct a drill on Tuesday as part of security preparedness ahead of the Brics Summit. SANCHIT KHANNA/HT

security initiatives to counter drug trafficking and terrorism and ensure the security of communication and hi-tech systems will also be on the agenda, he said.

The Brics leaders are set to

continued on →9

→MODI-PUTIN MEET TO BOLSTER TIES→P7

35 SPECIAL AIRCRAFT TO ARRIVE IN CAPITAL

With around 35 special aircraft, including VIP flights and charter planes carrying delegations, expected to arrive in Delhi for the Brics summit, authorities are working on a multi-airport plan to handle the air traffic.

→P7

OIL PRICES AT 6-WK HIGH AS HOUTHIS ATTACK SAUDI ENERGY FACILITIES

NEW YORK/BENGALURU/SINGAPORE: Oil prices rose to a six-week high on Tuesday after Iran-backed Houthis in Yemen attacked Saudi energy facilities, setting oil installations ablaze and threatening a major expansion of the six-month-old West Asia war.

Brent crude futures rose 70 cents, or 0.7%, to \$97.70 a barrel at 10:56 a.m. EDT (1456 GMT), while US West Texas Intermediate (WTI) crude rose \$1.21, or 1.3%, to \$92.69. That puts Brent on track for its highest close since July 23 and WTI on track for its highest close since June 4.

The Houthis attacked four cities of US ally Saudi Arabia on Tuesday, wounding over 70 people. Houthi-controlled media reported that Saudi warplanes had carried out four airstrikes in Yemen's Jubah district.

→P11

Modi: India's strong growth is boosting global confidence

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MUMBAI: India's strong growth was giving confidence to the world and the government will continue with economic reforms, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Tuesday as he attacked the Opposition and called for the integration of UPI with the payment systems of more countries.

Modi spent the day in Gujarat and Maharashtra, first laying the foundation stones, inaugurating and dedicating to the



PM Narendra Modi

2 HELD FOR SECURITY BREACH NEAR VENUE OF PM'S ADDRESS

Mumbai Police late on Monday arrested two men for a security breach and impersonation at the Jio World Plaza, housed in the complex where Prime Minister Narendra Modi was scheduled to speak on Tuesday evening. A third person accompanying the two is missing. Rohan Parekh, 24, gained entry into the Jio World Plaza, part of the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre, at 4.50pm on Monday after telling security he worked with the PMO.

→P6

nation development projects worth ₹35,000 crore in Vadodara, then addressing the 'Namo for Viksit Bharat' programme,

continued on →9

ED WRITES TO DGP, SEEKS FIR AGAINST VIJAYAN, DAUGHTER AND SON-IN-LAW

KOCHI/NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate on Tuesday wrote to the Kerala DGP seeking an FIR against former chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter Veena T and son-in-law PA Mohammed Riyas, apart from some others, on charges of corruption and bribery in the CMRL-Exalogic case, officials aware of the matter CPI(M) leader Riyas said neither he nor his wife and father-in-law are afraid of any kind of investigation.

→P5



No UAPA in NIA chargesheet against 7 foreign mercenaries

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NEW DELHI: The National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Tuesday filed a chargesheet against American citizen Mathew Aaron VanDyke and six Ukrainians arrested earlier this year for allegedly training ethnic armed groups in Myanmar, but did not charge them under the stringent Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA). NIA, however, left the question of UAPA prosecution open, saying its investigation into the alleged conspiracy was continuing.



Mathew Aaron VanDyke

The chargesheet, filed before special judge Prashant Sharma at Rouse Avenue Courts, seeks prosecution of the seven under the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025, for allegedly violating the

conditions of their entry and stay in India. The court has fixed October 1 for consideration of the chargesheet. All seven are in judicial custody.

"We have filed a charge sheet against seven accused under the Immigration and Foreigners Act. The probe has been kept open in all other aspects, including the UAPA charges," NIA special public prosecutor Rahul Tyagi told HT.

NIA had initially registered the case on March 13 under Section 18 of UAPA and sections 21 and 23 of the Immigration and Foreigners Act, relating to illegal entry and violations of visa conditions.

→P6

Hockey team to sport blue jersey at Asian Games after saffron row

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NEW DELHI: Following the furore over choosing saffron-coloured jerseys instead of the traditional blue at the World Cup last month, the Indian hockey teams will wear blue once again at the Asian Games, which will be held in Japan from September 19 to October 4. However, this doesn't mean the saffron jersey has been dumped.

The Indian men's and women's

teams will, like always, have two jerseys. One will be a mix of white and sky blue, the other will be saffron. "The white on sky blue jersey is similar to what we wore at the last Asian Games in Hangzhou (in 2023)," an India player told HT. While Hockey India decides India's colours at bilateral or international hockey federation events such as the World Cup, the Indian Olympic Association decides the colours at multisport events such as the Olympics and Asian Games.

→P14

SC SEEKS BCCI REPLY ON INCLUSION IN SPORTS GOVERNANCE ACT

The Supreme Court on Tuesday sought the response of the BCCI and state cricket bodies to bring them under the National Sports Governance Act 2025. The bench said, "All cricket associations in the country are directed to take instructions on why the conditions of service of selected office bearers be not governed by the National Sports Governance Act 2025."

→P13

BAPS apologises after Eiffel Tower staff strike

PARIS: An influential Hindu group apologised after a controversial visit to the Eiffel Tower prompted a staff strike that shut the landmark for a day.

The apology follows allegations that female employees were asked to leave their workstations or stay out of sight during the visit by Bochasanwasi Akshar Purushottam Swaminarayan Sanstha, or BAPS, media reports said.

In a statement, the company that runs the Eiffel Tower said that BAPS had asked for interac-

tions to be "limited" during the visit, a request that it shouldn't have accepted.

The BAPS delegation was in Paris to inaugurate a Hindu temple. In a post on X on Tuesday, BAPS apologised "to anyone who may have been hurt or inconvenienced by this situation."

Paris mayor also Emmanuel Gregoire announced two investigations into the incident, calling the decision to sideline female staff "absurd, unjust and unacceptable".

→P2

KHARGE EVENT ROW: U'KHAND POLICE LODGE FIR

DEHRADUN/HALDWANI: An FIR has been lodged against an unidentified person in Uttarakhand's Haldwani, for allegedly conducting a "purification" ritual at a public ground following an event attended by Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge, and circulating an allegedly doctored video aimed at inciting communal and caste-based enmity, officials said on Tuesday. "If more people are identified during the probe, their names will be added to the FIR," SP (city) Manoj Katyal said.

→P5

{ **TRAFFICKING FEARS** } NATIVE TO INDONESIA, MALAYSIA

5 baby orangutans rescued from Odisha reserve forest, govt probing 'int'l mafia'

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BHUBANESWAR: Five young orangutans, typically found in the forests of Southeast Asia, have been rescued from a forested area in coastal Odisha, prompting the state forest and wildlife officials to investigate whether they were being smuggled through an international wildlife trafficking net-

work, people familiar with the matter said.

The orangutans, estimated to be aged between one and two, were found in the Ranakatha Protected Reserve Forest in Baleswar district, said principal chief conservator of forests (wildlife) Prem Kumar Jha. Orangutans are native to parts of Indonesia and Malaysia and are not naturally found in India.

→P5



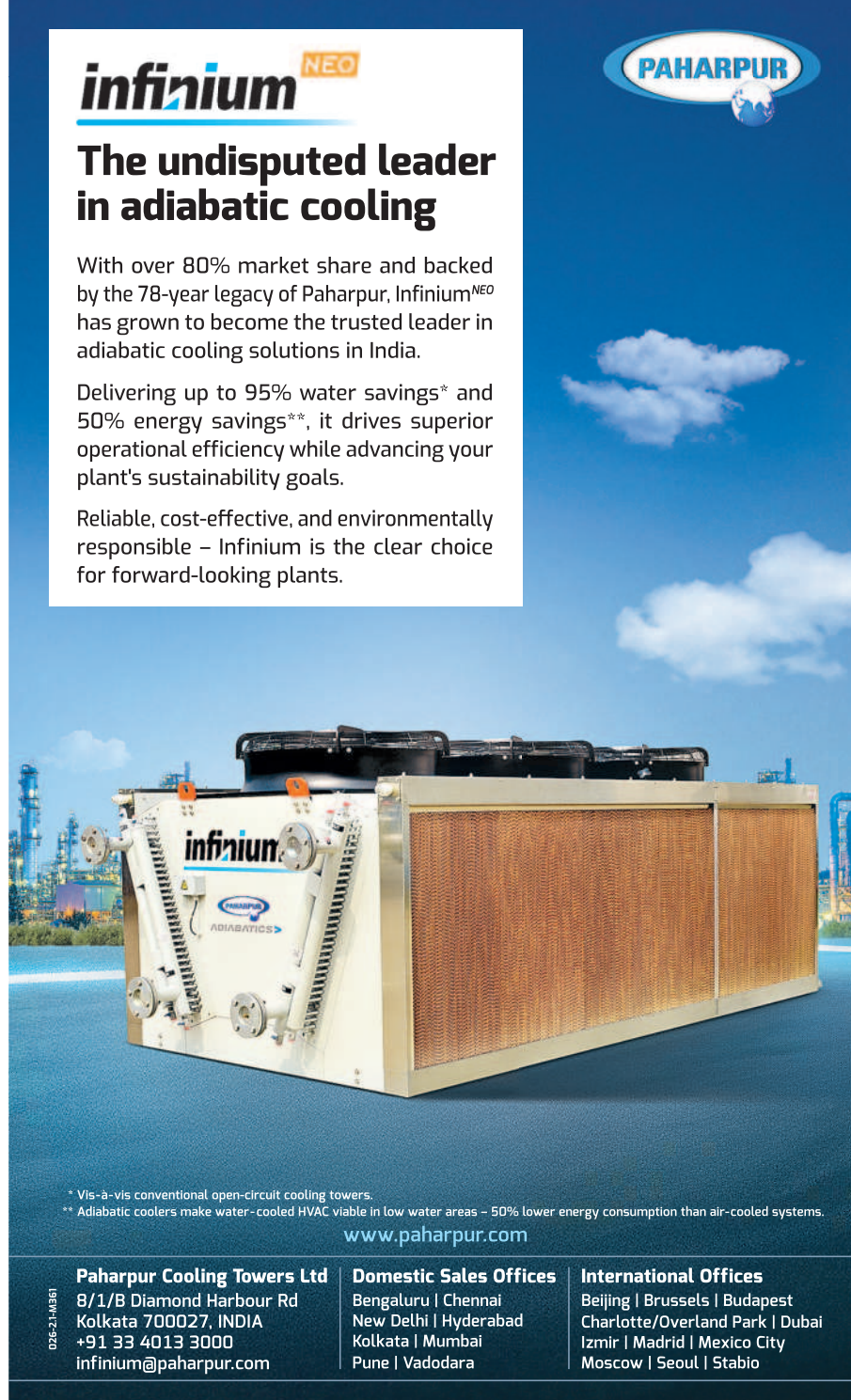
The orangutans were rescued from Bichitrapur forest area. PTI

DELHI TO SPEND ₹100CR ON 1,000 'ANTI-SMOG' GUNS

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has approved ₹100 crore to purchase 1,000 truck-mounted "anti-smog" guns to be operated in winter over three years, officials told HT on Tuesday, citing plans submitted to the Commission for Air Quality Management. The machines spray a fine mist that, at least notionally, should tamp dust. But there is little, if not no, evidence such devices work.



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{ MY INDIA } STAINES' MURDER CASE
SC slams Odisha for Dara Singh plea delay



The Supreme Court on Tuesday pulled up the Odisha government for delaying a decision on the remission plea of Rabindra Pal Singh, the convict in the murder of Australian missionary Graham Staines and his two sons, and threatened to summon the concerned secretary if a decision is not taken by September 17. Noting that the matter has been pending with the state for two years, the court said, "Why are you unnecessarily delaying the matter?" The state sought an adjournment, citing the illness of its advocate-on-record PV Yogeswaran. A junior lawyer appearing on his behalf said she had no instructions from the state or the Sentence Review Board (SRB) considering Singh's remission plea. **HTC**

{ MY INDIA } MURDER FOR DOWRY
UP: Judge awards 23rd death sentence



Additional district and sessions judge of Muzaffarnagar, Ravi Kumar Diwakar awarded his 23rd death sentence in five months, and said that he would prefer death to being called a "coward judge". The statement came in a ruling wherein he sentenced a man — convicted of settling his wife ablaze for dowry in 2018 — to death. The judgment highlighted alleged threats, pressure on the judiciary and the influence of gangsters and mafias in UP. "I would prefer to die rather than be called a cowardly judge. Earlier, the district judge recalled 100 cases from justice Diwakar's court and transferred them to other courts. **HTC**

{ MY INDIA } ON LEAVE FOR PERSONAL REASONS
With Sinha on leave, Ladakh LG gets addl charge of J&K



President Droupadi Murmu on Tuesday gave Ladakh lieutenant governor VK Saxena (left) the additional charge of Jammu & Kashmir till the incumbent, Manoj Sinha (right), returns from leave. Sinha is in Chicago to visit family and attended an alumni event of the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) on Sunday. One officer aware of the matter said the move was required for the swearing-in of the chief justice of the Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh high court. Sinha, who left on September 2, is expected to be back by September 15. There has been speculation that the Union territory may get a new LG, since Sinha finished six years in office in August. There was no confirmation of such a plan. **HTC**

{ MY INDIA } HT INTERVIEW
Cong leaders united in Pjb win push: Pilot



Congress general secretary Sachin Pilot, who was recently appointed in-charge of Punjab, maintains that all senior party leaders in the state have assured him of work with unity ahead of the assembly polls. In an interview to HT, the AICC member talks about his new role as well as the party's prospects in the upcoming Punjab polls. "All of us want the Congress to win. I had a cordial meeting with [former Punjab chief minister and Congress MP Charanjit Singh] Channi and he has assured me that he will offer his full support to the party's efforts for the election," he said. **→PS**

{ MY INDIA } DEFENCE PARTNERSHIP
Rajnath on 3-day visit to Sri Lanka



Defence minister Rajnath Singh reached Colombo on Tuesday for a three-day official visit aimed at strengthening maritime and defence partnership between India and Sri Lanka, the defence ministry said. "Leading a high-level delegation, Raksha Mantri will hold talks with the leadership of Sri Lanka on a range of issues to further strengthen traditionally strong and friendly bilateral relations in mutually beneficial areas including a strong maritime & defence partnership. He will also interact with the Indian diaspora in Colombo during the visit," the ministry said on X. Singh said he looked forward to a productive engagement with the Sri Lankan leadership. **HTC**

How attacks on flights reshaped air travel in US

Associated Press

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Taking a commercial flight from a US airport generally requires a boarding pass to get near a gate, security screening controlled by the federal government and careful attention to carry-on bags.

It wasn't always this way.

The security system travelers encounter today was built layer by layer, often after attacks or attempted attacks exposed new vulnerabilities — from bombs hidden in luggage to hijackers who turned airplanes into weapons.

No single day changed air travel more dramatically than September 11, 2001.

Before then, authorities presumed aircraft hijackers would seek to negotiate, not deliberately crash a plane as part of an attack.

The Federal Aviation Administration immediately restricted airport gate access to ticketed passengers and banned knives and box cutters from carry-on bags. Congress created the Transportation Security Administration, shifting responsibility for screening passengers, baggage and other cargo to a federal workforce. The same law required reinforced cockpit doors, more federal air marshals and 100% screening of checked luggage for explosives.

The range of security flaws that 9/11 exposed came after authorities and the industry had spent more than a decade addressing gaps revealed by earlier attacks.

Almost 13 years before 9/11, a bomb destroyed a jumbo jet operated by a US airline as it flew at 31,000 feet over Lockerbie, Scotland, killing all 259 people aboard and 11 on the ground. Investigators determined an explosive device hidden in a radio-cassette player had been inside a suitcase checked in Malta and ultimately transferred to Pan Am Flight 103 without an accompanying passenger.

The December 21, 1988, attack on the London-to-New York flight "stimulated the most significant changes in aviation security since the early 1970s," former FAA Administrator Jane Garvey told the 9/11 Commission in 2003.

The FAA ordered US carriers at airports in Europe and the Middle

East to X-ray or physically search all checked baggage.

The FAA also assigned security personnel at major US and foreign airports, established intelligence-sharing agreements, tightened cargo controls and developed explosives-detection technology.

Three months and 11 days after 9/11, Richard Reid boarded American Airlines Flight 63 from Paris to Miami with explosives hidden in his shoes. He tried to ignite them midflight but was subdued by passengers and crew. After the Dec. 22, 2001, incident, TSA and airlines asked passengers to remove their shoes voluntarily during security screening. Shoe removal became mandatory less than five years later, when TSA also restricted outside liquids and gels.

The changes followed a British announcement that authorities had disrupted a plot to use liquid explosives concealed in beverage bottles to destroy seven transatlantic airliners. TSA immediately banned nearly all liquids, gels and aerosols beyond security screening, later replacing the prohibition with the "3-1-1" rule limiting passengers to containers of 3.4 ounces or less that must fit in a single quart-sized, clear plastic bag.

On Christmas Day 2009, a passenger on Northwest Airlines Flight 253 tried to detonate explosives hidden in his underwear as the plane approached Detroit. The device failed but caused a fire, and Umar Farouk Abdulmutallab was severely burned. He pleaded guilty to attempting to destroy the aircraft. Traditional metal detectors could not detect the plastic explosives under Abdulmutallab's clothes. TSA was already testing full-body scanners, and the incident persuaded authorities to fast-track the technology.

Security screening continues to evolve. TSA has been expanding facial recognition technology to verify passengers' identities. As of last month, newly manufactured passenger airplanes must have a retractable security gate between the cabin and flight deck to protect the cockpit when its reinforced main door is open. The Air Line Pilots Association wants the secondary barriers added to existing aircraft.

School students who use AI get worse test scores: OECD report

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Students who do not use AI chatbots for schoolwork are outperforming those who do, according to the OECD's flagship educational report, providing some of the widest-ranging evidence yet that the technology could be hurting children's learning.

Students who say they never or almost never use AI to draft texts for writing assignments scored 509 on a science test, according to the report, compared with 481 for students using AI for that purpose every day or almost every day. The 28-point gap, adjusted for socio-economic status, corresponds to roughly a year and a half of teaching.

Similar patterns appear for other uses of AI, including conducting preliminary research on a new topic and summarizing assigned reading.

"In the same way that we do

not become fit by watching sports but by doing sports, learning does not occur through the consumption of content, but as a productive cognitive struggle of the mind with new material," wrote OECD Director for Education and Skills Andreas Schleicher.

He said AI should be used as a "scaffold, not a crutch," adding: "Where technology enables or enhances that cognitive struggle, students will advance. Where technology short-circuits the productive struggle of learning, it will undercut students' development."

The Program for International Student Assessment tests 15-year-old students in science, math and reading, and is closely watched by politicians and policymakers as one of the leading measures of national education systems. The results, released Tuesday, are based on a representative sample of over 760,000 students across 91 countries.

25 YEARS LATER Sept 11, and what happens this year

A quarter century after the era-defining attacks of September 11, the US is eager to keep alive the memory of a 2001 trauma that is fading as the proportion of Americans who did not experience it firsthand grows.

A MEMORY STEADILY FADING?

100 million

Americans who were either not born in 2001 or too young to remember it, according to the 9/11 Memorial & Museum.

The museum, which draws 2.4mn unique visitors a year, has shifted its emphasis from remembrance to education, using trained volunteers — among them first responders and bereaved relatives — to reach audiences who know the attacks only through their parents or school.

THE LONG-LASTING TOLL

Beyond those killed on the day, more than 9,400 people have since died of illnesses related to the terror attack, according to a US programme set up to provide medical care to those affected.

2,977

People killed in the September 11 attacks across the US, including the 19 hijackers. Most deaths were in the World Trade Center.

6k-25k

Estimates of injuries from 9/11 vary depending on the source and methodology. The 25,000 figure extrapolates self-reported local data to the national level.

400k

A CDC report said that nearly 400,000 people were exposed to contaminants that affected their physical or mental health.

TRUMP, EX-PRESIDENTS TO MARK GRIM LANDMARK

Vice President JD Vance and all four living former presidents — Joe Biden, Barack Obama, Bill Clinton and George W Bush — are expected in Manhattan. Former first ladies Jill Biden and Laura Bush, and Hillary Clinton, are also slated to attend.

President Donald Trump will speak at the Pentagon instead. Reports said this came because the memorial has barred politicians from speaking at the site since 2012 to keep the event non-partisan; Trump has denied those reports.

SEVEN SILENCES

There will be seven moments of silence to mark the attacks

- 8.46am: Flight 11 hits the North Tower
- 9.03am: Flight 175 hits the South Tower
- 9.37am: Flight 77 hits the Pentagon
- 9.59am: The South Tower falls
- 10.03am: Flight 93 crashes near Shanksville
- 10.28 am: The North Tower falls.

A seventh: To be observed for the first time this year, follows the reading of names and honours those who died of illness and injury linked to the rescue, recovery and aftermath.

MASTERMIND SET FOR 2028 TRIAL

Khalid Sheikh Mohammed, the alleged mastermind and a lieutenant of Osama bin Laden, is scheduled to go on trial in June 2028 at the US naval base in Guantanamo Bay, Cuba.

{ PROCEDURAL HURDLE REMOVED }

Panel probe not prerequisite criteria for rights cases: SC

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has strengthened the hands of human rights courts by ruling that criminal proceedings for offences arising from human rights violations need not be preceded by an inquiry or recommendation from the national or state human rights commission.

A bench of justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said that the Protection of Human Rights Act, 1993 provides for two distinct and complementary mechanisms — the human rights commissions, which have an inquisitorial and recommendatory role, and human rights courts, which exercise judicial power to try offences arising from human rights violations.

The court held that an inquiry or recommendation by a human rights commission cannot be treated as an "indispensable condition precedent" to initiating criminal proceedings before a human rights court.

"To read such a limitation into the statute would amount to supplying a condition which Parliament itself has not enacted," said the bench in a judgment released earlier this week.

The ruling is significant as it removes a procedural hurdle that could have made human rights courts dependent on the prior intervention of human rights commissions, thereby preserving a victim's direct

INQUIRY BY HUMAN RIGHTS PANEL CAN'T BE TREATED AS 'INDISPENSABLE' TO INITIATING PROCEEDINGS BEFORE A HUMAN RIGHTS COURT, THE SC RULED

access to the criminal justice mechanism.

The ruling came while setting aside a Karnataka High Court judgment which had struck down Rule 6 of the Karnataka State Human Rights Courts Rules, 2006, and consequently quashed criminal proceedings against police officials accused of violating the human rights of a man in custody.

The case arose after Sayad Asifulla, who was himself an accused in a criminal case registered in Vijayapura, filed a private complaint before the principal district and sessions judge and special judge, Human Rights Court, Vijayapura, alleging violation of his human rights by police officials in connection with his custody.

In January 2024, the human rights court directed investigation under the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC), following which a case was registered against the police officials.

The officials approached the Karnataka High Court, challenging the proceedings as

well as the validity of Rule 6. The high court accepted their plea in July 2025, holding that the rule was unconstitutional and beyond the rule-making power of the state government. It also quashed the criminal case.

The state, through its additional advocate general Avishkar Singhvi, assailed the high court judgment.

Asifulla also contested the ruling.

The Supreme Court allowed the appeals, pointing out that Sections 12 to 18 of the 1993 Act empower the human rights commissions to inquire into complaints, investigate violations and, where appropriate, recommend prosecution.

But Section 30 separately empowers the state government to designate a court of session in each district as a human rights court for the speedy trial of offences arising out of human rights violations.

There is nothing in Sections 12 to 18 of the 1993 Act making a commission's recommendation a prerequisite for prosecution, held the bench, adding that Section 30 too does not make the jurisdiction of a human rights court dependent on completion of proceedings before a commission.

The court also upheld Rule 6 of the 2006 Rules, which allows a victim, legal representative or, subject to prescribed safeguards, an NGO or public person to approach a human rights court with a complaint against a public servant alleged to have committed or abetted an offence involving violation of human rights.

The rule permits the court either to order a police investigation by an officer not below the rank of superintendent of Police or conduct its own inquiry in accordance with the procedure governing private complaints.

The bench said that the rule did not create a new offence or prescribe a new punishment but merely provided the procedural machinery necessary to invoke the jurisdiction of a human rights court already created under Section 30 of the parent law.

The bench rejected the argument that the human rights commission was the exclusive gateway for prosecution. It further noted a Supreme Court's 2021 ruling, which had recognised that complaints relating to use of force in police stations could be made either to the state human rights commission or the human rights court.

The two remedies, the bench said, were "distinct and complementary" and the human rights commission was not a mandatory gateway to the human rights court.

It also rejected the argument that permitting simultaneous recourse to the commission and the human rights court could result in double jeopardy, noting that an inquiry or recommendation by the commission does not amount to a prior prosecution or punishment.

Eiffel Tower reopens after strike, BAPS apologises for row

Agencies

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The Eiffel Tower reopened Tuesday, a day after one of the world's most-visited landmarks was closed by a strike to protest what a union official called "unacceptable" management instructions limiting the presence of women during a visit by a Hindu religious delegation on Saturday.

Diane Davoine of the CGT union told The Associated Press anger grew among staff of the iconic 330-meter (1,083-foot) tower over the weekend after management told employees that female workers should "not be in contact" with a visiting delegation from Bochasanwasi Shri Akshar Purushottam Swaminarayan Sanstha.

The group, known as BAPS, is a worldwide religious and civic organization within the Swaminarayan sect, a branch of Hinduism. It has been holding celebrations to mark the inauguration of a traditional Hindu stone temple in the French capital.

The operating company that runs the Eiffel Tower, SETE, acknowledged that the BAPS delegation had requested the visit on Saturday be organised so as to limit "interactions with women" and said that "these conditions should not have been accepted".

In a written statement emailed to the AP on Tuesday, the group said it coordinated with the Eiffel Tower's management to minimize disruption to staff and visitors ahead of a visit by a delegation of some 100 people. The coordination was "never, at any point, intended as a request

IN A MESSAGE ON X, THE MAYOR OF PARIS, EMMANUEL GREGOIRE, SAID HE WOULD LAUNCH 2 INVESTIGATIONS INTO THE INCIDENT

rooted in gender, and any suggestion to the contrary does not reflect the spirit or values of our fellowship or the delegation," the statement said.

In an earlier statement, the group offered "sincere apologies to anyone who may have been hurt or inconvenienced by this situation."

When asked about the controversy, External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said at a media briefing in New Delhi: "We are aware of the opening of a temple by the BAPS Sanstha in the Paris area. As to the particular issue pertaining to the Tower, this is a matter purely between the entities concerned."

Paris Mayor Emmanuel Gregoire announced two investigations into the incident, calling the decision to sideline female staff "absurd, unjust and unacceptable". The city of Paris, which "owns 99 percent" of the landmark, will conduct one probe, he added, while SETE will carry out a separate internal review with an external consultant.

Asked who had given the order, Gregoire said he was beginning to have "some information" but declined to elaborate.

MY BENGALURU

K'taka mulls moving SC against order to release Cauvery water

Press Trust of India

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka government is seriously considering approaching the Supreme Court against the CWRC direction to release Cauvery river water to Tamil Nadu at a rate of 6,000 cusecs a day for the next 15 days, the state's Water Resources Minister N Chaluvaryaswamy said on Tuesday.

Describing the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee's (CWRC) order as "absurd" and expressing anguish over it, he said Karnataka was facing a difficult situation due to a significant decline in inflows into the Cauvery basin over the past week.

The CWRC on Tuesday recommended directing Karnataka to ensure a flow of 6,000 cusecs of water to Tamil Nadu for 15

days, it was subsequently upheld by the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA).

"Our officials strongly argued the ground realities at the CWRC meeting, Tamil Nadu had sought 17,000 cusecs of water. However, inflows into the Cauvery basin have declined considerably over the past week. In such a distress situation, even releasing 6,000 cusecs is impossible for us. We are making continuous efforts to ensure that no water is released," Chaluvaryaswamy told reporters here following the CWRC directions and ahead of the CWMA meeting.

The minister also criticised the functioning of authorities taking decisions from Delhi, saying they were unable to understand the situation on the ground. "The Constitution and administration benches sitting

CWMA UPHELD CWRC SUGGESTION DIRECTING KARNATAKA TO ENSURE A FLOW OF 6,000 CUSECS OF WATER TO TAMIL NADU FOR 15 DAYS

in Delhi do not understand the ground realities. There have been instances in the past when similar orders were issued without understanding the actual situation," he said.

Chaluvaryaswamy said the government did not expect much relief from the CWMA meeting and would discuss the matter with chief minister D K Shivakumar before deciding on approaching the Supreme Court.

"...we will discuss the matter with the chief minister. The government is seriously considering filing a petition in the Supreme Court tomorrow itself," he said.

On the water storage in the state's various reservoirs, the minister said around 50 per cent of the available water was being reserved exclusively for drinking water purposes. "Water has been supplied to farmers' crops as required through the Bhadra and Upper Krishna Project (UKP) in those regions. Water has also been released through the river to ensure there is no drinking water shortage in the Chitradurga region," he said.

He added that water from reservoirs was being managed in a controlled manner to fill lakes and ponds and prevent shortages for people and livestock.

The CWMA upheld the CWRC

recommendation directing Karnataka to ensure a flow of 6,000 cusecs of water to Tamil Nadu for 15 days. The decision was taken at the 57th meeting of the CWMA held in Delhi under the chairmanship of S K Haldar. Officials from Tamil Nadu and Karnataka participated in the meeting. Earlier in the day, the CWRC recommended Karnataka release water to Tamil Nadu. This follows the CWMA's earlier order on August 25 when, upholding the CWRC's recommendation, it had directed Karnataka to ensure a flow of 9,000 cusecs of water to Tamil Nadu for 15 days. The meeting was held following SC's direction to the Tamil Nadu government a day earlier to raise before the CWMA its grievance over the release of its proportionate share of Cauvery water by Karnataka.



Prajwal Revanna

PRAJWAL REVANNA IN 2-DAY POLICE CUSTODY OVER PHONE USE IN JAIL

Coovercolly Indresh

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BENGALURU: Police have taken former MP Prajwal Revanna and his former prison cellmate Pratap Rai into custody for two days as investigators seek to determine how a smartphone and other prohibited items entered Parappana Agrahara Central Prison.

The 42nd Additional Chief Metropolitan Magistrate Court granted the Parappana Agrahara police's request on Tuesday after the two men were produced before it on a body warrant. Revanna, listed as accused No. 2, was taken to nearby police station after hearing for questioning. Rai is accused No. 1 in the case. The investigation began after Central Crime Branch personnel searched the prison on August 11 and allegedly found a 5G smartphone inside a high security cell on the first floor. A charger, a pen drive and a scribbling pad were also recovered.

Police said the phone contained password protected applications, and investigators said the two men did not provide passwords during initial inquiry.

The custodial interrogation is expected to focus on how the items entered prison, who supplied them and how the phone was used. During preliminary inquiry, Revanna reportedly said the scribbling pad belonged to him. Police said it contained telephone numbers of his relatives, friends and lawyer. Rai allegedly claimed ownership of the phone, charger and pen drive.

Prison personnel were suspended after the recovery over alleged lapses in supervision.

Revanna is serving a life sentence in a rape case while Rai is in prison in connection with a Pocco case.

HC allows private complaint against Kcharge's trust

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka High Court has allowed a private complaint alleging irregularities in the allotment of a civic amenity site in Bengaluru to a trust associated with Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and his family to proceed, rejecting a plea to stop the proceedings.

The dispute concerns an 8,125-sq-m site in Banashankari allotted by the Bengaluru Development Authority (BDA) to the Siddhartha Vihar Trust. The complainant, Vijayraghava Marathe, has alleged violations in the allotment process and questioned a concession that reduced the lease consideration.

Marathe has alleged that the trust claimed Scheduled Caste status while applying for the site and consequently received a 50% concession on the lease amount. He has also alleged collusion between BDA officials and beneficiaries of the allotment. Those named in the complaint have disputed the allegations.

Justice M Nagaprasanna was hearing Marathe's challenge to the manner in which the complaint was taken up by the Special Court dealing with cases involving parliamentarians and members of legislative assembly.

Rather than directing the Lokayukta police to register a case and investigate, the special court chose to proceed with the private complaint under Section 223 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita.

The BNSS section governs the examination of complainants and witnesses by a Magistrate when taking cognizance of an offence on a private complaint.

Marathe had sought a police investigation under Section 175(3) of the BNSS, citing provisions of the Prevention of Corruption Act. He had also alleged that the Lokayukta police had failed to act on his complaint.

BNSS Section 175 (3) empowers a judicial magistrate to



Mallikarjun Kharge

order a police investigation and the registration of an FIR upon receiving a complaint about a cognizable offence.

Senior advocate Lakshmi Iyengar, appearing for Marathe, said the allegations required examination of the records and the conduct of officials involved in the allotment.

"The complaint raises specific allegations about the manner in which the civic amenity site was allotted and the concession extended to the trust. At this stage, what is required is examination of the allegations through the process of law," Iyengar said.

"The continuation of the complaint cannot be treated as a finding of guilt against any of the accused," the senior advocate added.

The complaint also raises questions about a separate allotment to the trust at the Aerospace Park by the Karnataka Industrial Areas Development Board. Marathe has questioned that allotment and alleged that the trust had no prior experience in aerospace or research activities.

The high court's order allows the private complaint to proceed. It does not, however, establish the allegations made in it.

The petitioner alleged that land was allotted in the Devanahalli Aerospace Park to the trust which lacked adequate experience in aerospace research. The land was returned after the allegations surfaced.

The petitioner has maintained that returning the land does not wipe out the alleged criminality and that the circumstances surrounding the allotment require investigation.

EC notice to Padma awardee withdrawn

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MANGALURU: Padma Shri awardee Harekala Hajabba, popularly known as the "letter saint," was briefly issued a Special Summary Revision notice by Election Commission regarding voter list verification. However, the notice was withdrawn by local Village Accountant hours after delivery.

The discrepancy stems from the 2002 electoral roll, where his name was recorded simply as "Hajabba." Subsequent official records updated his name to "Harekala Hajabba," leading to a mismatch during EC's routine verification process. All official documentation reflect his name as "Harekala Hajabba."

Hajabba said Anganwadi workers delivered the notice,



Harekala Hajabba with former President Ram Nath Kovind

directing him to appear before Gram Panchayat with original supporting documents on September 11. "All my official documents carry the name 'Harekala Hajabba,'" he said. He added Village Accountant Ashwini visited him to withdraw the document. Dakshina Kannada deputy commissioner Darshan H said the notice was generated as part of standard verification process.

St Mary's annual feast in Bengaluru



People gather to witness the grand chariot procession of Mother Mary marking the culmination of St Mary's annual feast at Shivajinagar, in Bengaluru on Tuesday.

AUTHORITIES DENY PERMISSION TO BJP FOR BALLARI PADAYATRA EVENT

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

BALLARI: Authorities have denied the BJP permission to hold a September 10 public meeting at the Government Pre-University College ground here to mark the conclusion of its 10-day padayatra (foot march) against the alleged corruption and failures of the Congress government. The state BJP on Tuesday alleged that district authorities were under pressure from the Congress government to deny permission.

Authorities cited a 2015 government order stating that the grounds and buildings of Government Pre-University Colleges cannot be provided to private organisations or associations for public or private functions, exhibitions, sales stalls, entertainment programmes and other such events.

The BJP's 'Ballari Chalo' padayatra, which began at Lingasugur in Raichur district on September 1, is scheduled to conclude in Ballari on September 10. Led by BJP state president B Y Vijayendra, several party leaders, MLAs, MLCs, state office-bearers, district presidents and party workers are taking part in the march.

In a communication dated September 7 to Ballari district BJP president Anil Kumar Moka, the deputy director of the School Education Department (Pre-University) for Ballari and Vijayanagara districts cited the 2015 order and said strict instructions had been issued against allowing the grounds and buildings of Government Pre-University Colleges to be used for such events. The communication said the principal of the concerned college would be held responsible and disciplinary action would be initiated in case of non-compliance.

The BJP had sought permission to hold the meeting at the ground from 3 pm to 8 pm on September 10 and informed the authorities that more than 50,000 people and dignitaries were expected to attend. Vijayendra alleged that the Ballari deputy commissioner was under pressure from the Congress government in the state.

He said he had received information that authorities were delaying permission for the concluding event of the padayatra in Ballari.

Leopard attacks forest watcher amid rescue op

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BELAGAVI: An injured leopard attacked a forest department employee during a rescue operation near Anagoddu on National Highway 48 in Davangere district after the animal was hit by an unidentified vehicle, officials said on Tuesday.

The leopard was crossing the highway around 11 pm on Monday when it was struck by the vehicle. It fell into a roadside

LEOPARD WAS INJURED AFTER IT WAS STRUCK BY VEHICLE WHILE CROSSING NH 48

drain and was found struggling to move. Residents then informed the forest department.

A team of officials began efforts to remove the leopard from the drain and take it for treatment. The animal was trans-

quillised during the operation, but the sedative had not taken full effect when it suddenly charged at one of the rescuers.

Forest watcher Maralusiddaiah, 35, suffered injuries to his right leg in the attack, Davangere Assistant Conservator of Forests Shanmukha said. "He was injured when the leopard suddenly attacked one of our rescue team members while we were trying to lift the animal out of the drain," Shanmukha said.

The leopard knocked the for-

est employee to the ground before other members of the team intervened and drove the animal away. Maralusiddaiah was taken to a government hospital in Davangere. His condition was stable, Shanmukha said.

Rescue operation continued and the leopard was taken for treatment. Officials said it will likely be shifted to Tyavarekoppa Wildlife Rescue and Rehabilitation Centre in Shivamogga. Officials have not yet identified the vehicle that struck the leopard.



CM DK Shivakumar interacts with farmers and traders at Yeshwanthpur APMC Yard in Bengaluru on Tuesday.

Crop insurance claims of 93 farmers rejected over payment lapse

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BENGALURU: Ninety three farmers in Devar Hipparagi taluk had their crop insurance claims rejected after the self help society through which they had paid their premiums failed to remit money to district central cooperative bank, chief minister D K Shivakumar said on Tuesday.

Shivakumar directed officials to dismiss the secretary of the self help society after a farmer complained that the farmers had paid their insurance premiums but were later informed that their claims had been rejected because the money was not remitted to the DCC bank.

The farmer told Shivakumar that the farmers had paid the money to the self help society and had received messages saying their insurance had been rejected. Shivakumar checked the list of farmers who had made the payments and directed officials to act against the official responsible.

The issue came up during Shi-

vakumar's surprise visit to the Yeshwanthpur APMC market, where he spoke to onion, garlic, potato and coconut growers, traders and mandi owners about their problems.

Shivakumar asked farmers whether police stopped them while bringing produce to the market, whether they were being paid on time, whether traders were collecting commissions and whether their produce was being weighed correctly.

Farmers told him that traders in Kalaburagi, Bidar and Vijayanagara markets charged commissions of Rs 8 to Rs 10, while no commission was collected from farmers at Yeshwanthpur. They also complained about poor onion yields because of inadequate rainfall. They also said excessive rain could cause onions to rot in fields, while transporting crop to the market could cost more than returns.

During the inspection, the CM also noticed children working at APMC market and directed police to act against those employing children.

DyCM: 25 taluks likely to be declared drought-hit

Press Trust of India

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BENGALURU: Karnataka Deputy chief minister G Parameshwara on Tuesday said that 25 more taluks have qualified to be declared drought-hit in the second phase of assessment and will be notified shortly.

The assessment of drought conditions in the state is being carried out in phases, with 101

taluks already declared drought-hit in the first phase, he said.

Parameshwara said there was no delay in declaring drought-hit areas and the assessment would continue as long as there was a shortfall in both monsoon and post-monsoon rainfall. "Last time, nearly 200 taluks were declared drought-hit. This year too, there is a possibility that over 200 taluks may eventually be declared drought-hit," he said.

Kevin Mendonsa

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MANGALURU: Student Ayisha Afra was forced to abandon her undergraduate studies at University College, Hampankatta, in Dakshina Kannada district during the 2022 hijab controversy, but she refused to let the setback define her. Few days ago, she celebrated a major victory: graduating with a B.E. in Biotechnology from P.A. College of Engineering, affiliated with Visvesvaraya Technological University (VTU), Mangaluru.

A resident of Babbukatte in Thokkottu, Afra originally enrolled in a B.Sc. in Botany programme in 2020, aiming to clear the GATE exam and pursue a master's degree in the same discipline. However, her academic plans were derailed at the start of her second year when the hijab controversy broke out.

"Though I searched for another college offering the same subject combination, I found none, leaving me with no choice but to drop out entirely,"

Afra shared. "I was deeply upset about the row and having to abandon a subject I was passionate about. However, my parents were immensely supportive and encouraged me to pivot. That's when I discovered the Biotechnology programme at P.A. College of Engineering—another field I loved that was also close to home."

Afra excelled in her new environment, graduating with a CGPA of 9.26 out of 10 and contributing to two research publications during her studies. Reflecting on her journey, she noted that while the transition was challenging at first, she adapted well and is now actively applying for jobs in her field.

Afra is among several Muslim women who managed to rebuild their educational paths following the 2022 controversy. Gousiya, another student forced to leave University College after her fifth semester, also achieved a major academic milestone.

Gousiya, a resident of Kalkamba, BC Road, recalled that six female students left the insti-



Ayisha Afra graduated with a B.E. in Biotechnology from P.A. College of Engineering in Mangaluru.

tution due to the controversy. "Four of us, including me, secured seats at Besant Women's College," she shared. "However, one student had to discontinue her studies because her subject combination was not offered anywhere else except at Univer-

sity College. Meanwhile, Afra quit her B.Sc. in Botany entirely to join engineering. None of us came from financially sound backgrounds. Those who completed their undergraduate degrees are now working, and some have married."

Since Gousiya had already completed her fifth semester before leaving, she missed her sixth-semester classes amid the dispute. "Students who left during their fifth semester were asked to return after a year to finish," she recalled. "During that break, I took up a job as a school teacher near Thokkottu."

After resuming her studies elsewhere, Gousiya went on to earn an M.Sc. in Medical Physics at Mangalore University's Mangalagangothi campus in Konaje, receiving her degree during the university's convocation in March. She secured a CGPA above 8.0 and an SGPA above 9.0 in her postgraduate programme, recently completing an internship at the Zulekha Yenepoya Institute of Oncology.

"I was at the center of the con-

court for a fresh decision. This leaves open the possibility that the sessions court could again allow Pradosh to turn approver after correcting the legal deficiencies identified in earlier proceedings," said a court official in the know of the development.

Pradosh had approached the trial court seeking pardon and permission to give evidence against the other accused. Darshan's lawyers opposed the request and challenged the manner in which the trial court had dealt with it.

"One of their objections concerned a report obtained from a probation officer about Pradosh.

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BENGALURU: Actor Darshan Thoogudeepa secured interim relief in Renukaswamy murder case on Tuesday after Karnataka high court set aside a trial court order that had allowed co-accused Pradosh Rao, the 14th accused, to become an approver.

Justice M. Nagaprasanna directed the 59th City Civil and Sessions Court to issue a fresh order within a week. The high court said that the trial court need not conduct another hearing but must reconsider the matter in accordance with the law.

The order came after Darshan challenged trial court's decision to permit the recording of Pradosh's statement as an approver. The HC had heard the petition on Monday and reserved its order before delivering the decision on Tuesday. "The HC has not barred Pradosh from becoming an approver. Instead, it has set aside the earlier order and sent the matter back to the trial

HC SAID THAT THE TRIAL COURT NEED NOT CONDUCT ANOTHER HEARING BUT MUST RECONSIDER THE MATTER AS PER THE LAW

The defence argued that seeking such a report was outside the probation officer's role in proceedings concerning an accused seeking pardon," the official said.

The defence also argued that Pradosh's marital status, family circumstances and conduct could not form the basis for deciding whether he should receive pardon under Section 54 of the Evidence Act.

According to the arguments presented before the high court, such personal circumstances had no bearing on the criminal proceedings.

The prosecution defended the trial court's procedure, arguing that information could be obtained by investigating officers or the court under the applicable rules. It acknowledged, however, that the prosecution had not sought the probation officer's report and that the trial court had obtained it on its own.

The high court's direction requires the trial court to address those issues before issuing its next order.

Students mark success post Hijab row setback

trovsky and was blamed for leading others," Gousiya recalled. "While the incident took a heavy mental toll, it ultimately made me stronger and driven to achieve more academically than I thought possible. My goal from day one has been to work in medical physics, and I am now aiming to become a Radiation Safety Officer."

While students like Afra and Gousiya successfully completed their degrees, others were forced to discontinue their higher education permanently due to the non-availability of their specialized subject combinations in alternative institutions under Mangalore University.

A retired professor from University College noted that certain subject combinations were exclusive to the campus. "Colleges that lacked those specific combinations left candidates with no choice but to quit the course entirely and explore other options," he said. "Unfortunately, one student had to discontinue her studies permanently."

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Tumultuous 34-day TN House session concludes

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: The seventeenth Tamil Nadu assembly concluded its inaugural session on Tuesday, capping 34 tumultuous days which featured the revised budget for the current financial year and laying of the administrative foundation for the new government, repeated walkouts by the DMK, and heated exchanges on law and order and corruption.

State finance minister N Marie Wilson began the session by presenting a revised state budget with a total outlay of ₹4,72,585 crore. It sought to highlight a long-term goal of taking the economy of Tamil Nadu to a \$1.5 trillion economy by 2036.

Key features included the *Annan Seer thittam* (Brother's wedding gift), *Thai Maaman Thanga Mothiram Thittam* (maternal uncle's gold ring scheme), allotment of ₹1,32 crore for infrastructure improvement in 3,734 schools and also provisions for bicycles with helmets to over 5.3 lakh high-school students.

The DMK, and AIADMK, however, alleged that the budget featured nothing but co-opted schemes introduced by previous governments.

During the session, the state government also released the *Vetri Tamilaga* vision document with elements of 436 policy proposals under the theme *Aram* (Virtue), *Porul* (Prosperity) and *Inbam* (Well-being). It has been organised into 10 pillars and 54 sub-pillars.

Besides, the budget statement, the Assembly session also passed several resolutions which include opposition to delimitation rejecting the Centre's population based delimitation. It



DMK legislators stage a protest demanding expunction of CM C Joseph Vijay's remarks on MISA at the assembly session's penultimate proceedings on Tuesday.

demand a permanent freeze on Lok Sabha seats at the current 543 aimed at safeguarding Tamil Nadu's existing 39 seats.

Second, the Assembly session also saw passing of a resolution on abolition of National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) and sought a permanent exemption for Tamil Nadu.

Another resolution passed in the Assembly was *Tamil Thai Vaazhithu* to be sung first at any events in educational institutions, universities, government offices and public sector undertakings.

The assembly witnessed passing of a resolution to ensure that Tamil is used as a 'principal language' in the Madras High Court. The resolution urged the Union government to recognise Tamil as the principal language of proceedings and judgements in the Madras High Court alongside English.

Vijay also announced the expansion of Perunthalaivar Kamarajar Breakfast Scheme to

cover primary school students from class VI to VIII across government and government aided schools.

Vijay also announced that the establishment of a new Secretariat complex at an outlay of ₹1,200 crore that would be spread across 20 lakh sq ft in Chennai. He said the existing Fort St George which houses the Assembly and the Secretariat does not have sufficient space for taking up an expansion and underlined that after the new Secretariat complex was built, the existing Fort St George would be preserved as heritage monuments.

The month long session also saw the waiving of cooperative loans to farmers upto ₹1 lakh to alleviate agrarian distress.

Amid heated debates and arguments witnessed in the assembly, the chief minister warned the opposition against corruption, financial irregularities garnering sharp comments from the DMK members.

LEFT PARTIES WILL NOT ATTEND TVK MEET ON SEPT 9: SENIOR LEADER

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CHENNAI: The Left parties—Communist Party of India and the Communist Party of India (Marxist)—which offer "outside" support to the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) government would not attend the Coordination Committee Meeting scheduled to be held on September 9 near Chennai, senior party leaders said on Tuesday.

The ruling TVK has called for the Coordination Committee Meeting on September 9 to formalise the alliance in Tamil Nadu and to discuss about the upcoming local body elections and Parliament elections. TVK minister for school education A Rajmohan had said a name for the alliance led by his party would also be formally announced on that day.

Meanwhile, making their stand clear on the issue whether Left parties would attend the meeting or not, CPI(M) general secretary P Shanmugam explained in detail that members from his party would not take part. However, the Left parties would continue to offer its support from the outside to ensure that the government continues its term.

Recalling that four ministers from the TVK government met the Left party leaders on September 4 at their office, Shanmugam said, "During their visit, the ministers asked us to attend the meeting scheduled to be held tomorrow (September 9) at their office near Chennai."

"We asked about the purpose of the meeting for which they told that it is being called to form a new coalition under TVK, to create a minimum common programme for that coalition and to face upcoming elections including local body elections and the next parliamentary elections on behalf of the alliance," Shanmugam said.

The senior party leader said the CPI(M) has decided not to participate in the meeting called by the TVK with the intention of forming a coalition.

ED writes to DGP seeking FIR against Vijayan, kin

Press Trust of India

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KOCHI/NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate has written to the Kerala DGP seeking an FIR against former chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter Veena T, and son-in-law PA Mohammed Riyas and some others in connection with the CMRL-linked alleged bribery case, people familiar with the matter said on Tuesday.

The central agency sent a communication under section 66 (2) of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) citing findings from its investigation in the case, sources told PTL.

This section under the anti-money laundering law empowers the ED to share findings of its criminal investigation with a law enforcement agency for registration of a fresh FIR or complaint. The ED can book a PMLA case based on such a police case.

The ED has sought registration of a police FIR from the Kerala Director General of Police (DGP) against Vijayan, Veena, her husband and former minister Riyas and some others under the provisions of the Prevention of Corruption Act and other laws on the basis of "evidence" recovered during its probe and searches conducted in this case under the PMLA, the people said.

It is alleged by ED that Kerala mining firm Cochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd (CMRL) made fraudulent payments worth ₹2.78 crore to Veena's now-defunct company Exalogic Solutions under the guise of 'IT consultancy services'.



Pinarayi Vijayan

The federal agency raided Veena, who was living with Vijayan at a rented accommodation in the state capital Thiruvananthapuram, in June and subsequently questioned her.

It had said in a statement in August that some "handwritten" notes were seized during searches against Veena T and these contained details of certain fund transfers to Dubai.

There was no immediate reaction from Vijayan family.

Meanwhile, CPI(M) state secretary MV Govindan claimed that the ED was now trying to target Riyas. Vijayan had earlier called the ED case against his daughter as a political vendetta.

The ED claimed that the CMRL management and Veena generated "proceeds of crime". The PMLA case was filed in March 2024 after the ED took cognisance of a complaint registered by the Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO), the investigation arm of the ministry of corporate affairs, which later filed a prosecution complaint (charge sheet) before an Ernakulam court in April 2025.

The CMRL was caught in the cross hairs of central probe agencies following an Income Tax Department raid in January 2019.

CMRL CASE: NOT AFRAID OF ANY PROBE, SAYS CPI(M)'S RIYAS

Press Trust of India

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: CPI(M) leader PA Mohamed Riyas on Tuesday said that neither he nor his wife Veena T and father-in-law Pinarayi Vijayan are afraid of any kind of investigation against them in connection with the alleged CMRL bribery case as they have done no wrong.

Riyas was responding to reporters' queries regarding an Enforcement Directorate (ED) letter to the Kerala DGP seeking registration of an FIR against him, Vijayan and Veena in connection with the CMRL-linked alleged bribery case.

Riyas, also an MLA from Bepore assembly constituency, said that they will face the investigation legally. "Any kind of investigation can be carried out. None of us have done any wrong. There is no need for us to be afraid. The innocent shall remain innocent no matter what kind of probe is carried out," the former minister contended.

He also claimed that the political motives behind the ED action had already been revealed before everyone. Riyas also termed the ED claims as a "good script" and said that he was confident that "no kind of investigation will affect us in any way. So, we are not scared."

2 BRS MLCs suspended for rest of session over derogatory remarks

Press Trust of India

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HYDERABAD: BRS MLCs Tata Madhusudhan and N Naveen Kumar Reddy were on Tuesday suspended for the remainder of the Legislative Council session for the alleged derogatory remarks made by them against Assembly Speaker Gaddam Prasad Kumar.

Council Chairman Gutha Sukhender Reddy announced the suspension of the two members following a motion moved by Legislative Affairs Minister D Sridhar Babu.

State Congress president and MLC B Mahesh Kumar Goud demanded the immediate suspension of the two members from the Council, while other members also condemned the

alleged abusive comments against Speaker Kumar, who is a Dalit leader.

Goud said people of Telangana would not forgive if the presence of the two members continued in the House. The alleged derogatory remarks of Madhusudhan triggered a massive political row and rocked the proceedings of the assembly on September 7, 8.

Uproar in TN assembly over Vijay's gesture; DMK members evicted

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: A gesture made by Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay during his speech in the assembly, in which he targeted Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam president MK Stalin, came under scrutiny on Tuesday after some alliance partners of the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam strongly objected to it.

During his speech, Vijay made a gesture apparently mocking Stalin over his detention during the Emergency. During the arrest, Stalin had suffered a fractured jaw after being assaulted by police while in custody.

A video of Vijay touching his right jaw in the assembly was widely shared on social media, triggering a controversy and sharp criticism, including from CPI(M) state secretary P Shanmugam. Vijay, however, clarified on Tuesday that the gesture was "unintentional" and had no "ulterior motive" behind it.

Meanwhile, talking to X, Vijay wrote on his official profile as



C Joseph Vijay

TVK chief, "I wish to clarify that during my reply on the police demand for grants in the Legislative Assembly on September 7, 2026 my body language was purely unintentional and had no underlying intent whatsoever. Therefore, I kindly request that it not be interpreted as an act meant to hurt anyone personally."

Shanmugam said Vijay's reply did not address questions raised by members on law and order, and other key issues. "During the Emergency, former CM Stalin was assaulted and his jaw was fractured. Body shaming or making derogatory remarks about someone's appearance is condemnable," he said.

Meanwhile, Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) lawmakers were evicted en masse from the assembly after they objected to Vijay's remarks on the Sarkaria Commission and the Maintenance of Internal Security Act (MISA). The DMK MLAs demanded that the comments should be expunged from the record.

The legislators led by party whip EV Velu, former DMK minister KN Nehru along with his colleagues including PK Sekar Babu, Austin staged a demonstration near the Speaker's chair raising slogans while some resorted to sit on the floor, as the Speaker JCD Prabhakar denied to entertain their request.

However, the Speaker said in several occasions, debates were held on Sarkaria Commission and the chief minister made those comments by citing the reports of the Enforcement Directorate (ED).

Following a continued protest, the Speaker asked the assembly marshals to evict the DMK MLAs from the House.

HC extends stay on EC notifying bypolls to five TN assembly seats

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BENGALURU: The Madras High Court on Tuesday extended its interim stay until September 28, on the Election Commission notifying bypolls to five Tamil Nadu assembly constituencies.

The need for bypolls arose after chief minister C Joseph Vijay, who had won from both Perambur and Tiruchirappalli East in the 2026 assembly elections, retained Perambur and resigned from the Tiruchirappalli East seat.

Last week, Vijay had argued before the court that keeping the seats vacant for an indefinite period would deprive millions of voters deprived of democratically elected representatives to voice their interests, causes and grievances in the assembly.

He had made the submission in a counter-affidavit filed last week in a public interest litigation brought by Tirunelveli resident K Venkatachalapathy.

The court had on July 10

THE NEED FOR BYPOLLS AROSE AFTER CM, WHO WON FROM BOTH PERAMBUR AND TIRUCHIRAPPALLI EAST, RETAINED PERAMBUR SEAT

restrained EC from notifying by-elections to Tiruchi East, Perundurai, Ambasamudram, Virudhachal and Karur. The vacancies arose after the elected MLAs resigned, while defeated candidates in the constituencies had separately challenged the election results through election petitions before the high court.

Seeking an end to the interim restraint, Vijay had argued that the court should balance the interests of the election petitioners against those of the voters who currently have no elected MLA to represent them.

The high court will hear the matter for final hearing from September 28 onwards.

{ TN'S PLAN TO SHIFT SECRETARIAT, REVIVE FORT ST GEORGE }

Scholars flag fractured ownership, imperial ghosts

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: In the wake of the Tamil Nadu government's indication of shifting the centre of state power out of the historic Fort Saint George, citing practical constraints in housing ever-expanding administrative expenditure and staff inside the over 300-year-old crumbling complex, the core of which was completed in 1652, historians and enthusiasts mulled the implications and associated problems the proposed change presents.

Chief minister C Joseph Vijay recently announced a decision to establish a new Secretariat complex spanning around 20,000 square feet at an outlay of ₹1,200 crore. He noted that while Fort Saint George spanned a total of 107 acres, only 4 acres was under the control of the government. Soon after assuming office, he undertook a tour of the complex, which covered the Church of St Mary's, established in the 1680s, and the Fort Museum.

However, Vijay clarified that after the completion of the new Secretariat, the government



Historians noted that the complex of the Fort in the seventeenth century, as depicted in this 1754 painting by Dutch artist Jan Van Ryne (left) formed the core of the city of Madras (now Chennai) and witnessed several key developments of South India's modern history, even as it later became the principal seat of power for the Tamil Nadu government.

planned to preserve Fort Saint George as a heritage monument. Currently, the administrative wing of the complex is mostly out of bound to tourists.

Historian Sriram V said the complex may be regarded an emblem of colonial power, but also served as the core "out of which Chennai grew".

He noted the ownership dis-

putes underpinned maintenance issues around several buildings in the complex.

Various sections of the Fort were currently controlled by the state government, the legislature, the Indian Army and Navy and the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI).

"For example, the army is responsible for maintaining the

barracks within the complex. However, the King's Barracks today stands as a roofless shell due to an ongoing dispute between the Archaeological Survey of India and the Army over its ownership. The Army is reluctant to hand over the building to the ASI," he said.

The administrative wing was itself increasingly burdened by

the detritus of government machinery, he said. "Tonnes of rubbish lie behinds its (the Fort's) massive walls. These are the by-products of an administrative set-up that functions within the campus. Heaps of plastic, paper and other discarded items are visible", said Sriram.

He suggested that the govern-



Nara Lokesh

YSRCP: LOKESH MUST RESIGN OVER 2025 DSC HIRING IRREGULARITIES

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TADEPALLI: YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) demanded the immediate resignation of Education Minister Nara Lokesh and an impartial CBI inquiry into the alleged irregularities in DSC 2025 teacher recruitment.

Addressing separate press conferences, party official spokesperson Konda Rajiv Gandhi and former MP Margani Bharath said Lokesh should step down to pave the way for a free and fair investigation by a central agency.

They said numerous irregularities had surfaced in the recruitment process, including the alleged use of fake BC and sports-quota certificates. They alleged that even members of the same families secured jobs using mere participation certificates, according to the release.

The leaders said the Mega DSC had turned into a "job mela", where teacher posts were allegedly put up for sale. They maintained that strong evidence had emerged to substantiate these allegations.

They accused Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu of attempting to shield Lokesh. They recalled that former Chief Minister YS Rajasekhara Reddy had expressed readiness for a CBI inquiry when allegations were levelled against YS Jagan Mohan Reddy.

The leaders also alleged that the coalition government was silencing those questioning the DSC irregularities by filing cases against social-media activists, unemployed youth and journalists. They questioned why cases were not being filed against those who allegedly secured jobs using fake documents. The appointment of candidates without clearing the mandatory TET examination exposed the manner in which the process was conducted, they said.

administrative officers, village assistants, revenue inspectors and tahsildars.

The panel recommended departmental proceedings under relevant service rules against officers who served in these positions between May 2023 and June 19, 2024.

Recognising the socio-economic factors underlying the crisis, the report urged the state government to establish new industries in Kallakurichi to provide employment opportunities for educated, skilled and unskilled youth.

Alongside administrative reforms, the committee report tabled in the assembly also recommended a range of rehabilitation measures for affected families.

2 held for posing as PMO officials at Modi's event

Vinay Dalvi and Megha Sood

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MUMBAI: Two men were arrested by Mumbai police late on Monday for a security breach and impersonation at the Jio World Plaza which is housed in the same complex where Prime Minister Narendra Modi was scheduled to speak at the 7th Global Fintech Fest on Tuesday evening.

A third person accompanying the duo is missing, and the police have launched a search for him.

According to crime branch officers, Khar resident Rohan Parekh, 24, gained entry into the Jio World Plaza, a shopping mall that is part of the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre (NMACC), at 4.50 pm on Monday evening after telling security on ground that he worked with the Prime Minister's Office (PMO). Typically, the Special Protection Group (SPG) secures the convention centre five days in advance of the PM's arrival. The Jio Convention Centre has 22 gates and is spread over 17 acres in the heart of Bandra-Kurla Complex.

According to the police, Parekh, accompanied by two men, tried to gain entry into the Jio World Plaza and was stopped when the security



Rohan Parekh, one of the accused, being produced in Esplanade court on Tuesday.

ANSHUMAN POYREKAR/HT PHOTO

spotted one of the men carrying a gun. Parekh identified himself as a PMO official and showed an identity card on his phone, and was allowed in. The man carrying the gun said he was part of the SPG but was stopped along with the third man. Parekh came out of the plaza within a few minutes after which the trio left the venue.

But by this time the SPG had begun investigating Parekh's claim of being a PMO official and also the gun-toting man's claim of being a part of the SPG and found both to be bogus. A scan of the CCTV footage at the

entrance of the mall showed that the men had arrived in a Mercedes and the registration plate revealed that the car was registered in the name of Khar resident Rohan Premal Parikh, a resident of 12th Road in Khar West. A police team was then sent to the address to apprehend Parekh. He informed the cops that one of the men accompanying him was his friend Prathamesh Bagul, a Worli resident, while the other man carrying the gun was Dilip Kunde, his bodyguard and an ex-serviceman. Police subsequently arrested Kunde and seized a revolver and six live

cartridges from him, and are on the lookout for Bagul, 26. The two men have been remanded to police custody until September 11.

Parekh is the son of a diamond merchant and has a graduate degree in mathematics and physics from a university in the UK. His counsel, advocate Anandini Fernandes, told a metropolitan magistrate on Tuesday that Parekh himself could be a victim of a fraud. She said he was contacted by a certain Tarun Kapoor two years ago and offered a job in the PMO on a monthly salary of ₹68,000. Parekh, whose uncle has a drone equipment business, was told he was to work on defence policy in the PMO. She told the court that Parekh had received a letter purportedly signed by the PM himself, as also a digital identity card from the PMO. Nashik resident Kunde is a retired serviceman who works as a bodyguard for Parekh's father, and carries a licensed weapon.

The lawyer told the court the 24-year-old was recently engaged and had gone to the Jio Plaza to buy a perfume for his fiancée. She added that the Khar resident had no ill-intentions and had submitted all the material in his possession to the BKC police and later to the crime branch which is now investigating the case.



C Joseph Vijay

VIJAY'S GESTURE IN ASSEMBLY DRAWS FLAK FROM ALLIES

CHENNAI: A gesture made by Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay during his speech in the assembly, in which he targeted Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam president MK Stalin, came under scrutiny on Tuesday after some alliance partners of the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam strongly objected to it.

During his speech, Vijay made a gesture apparently mocking Stalin over his detention during the Emergency. During the arrest, Stalin had suffered a fractured jaw after being assaulted by police while in custody.

A video of Vijay touching his right jaw in the assembly was widely shared on social media, triggering a controversy and sharp criticism, including from CPI(M) state secretary P Shanmugam. Vijay, however, clarified on Tuesday that the gesture was "unintentional" and had no "ulterior motive" behind it.

Shanmugam said Vijay's reply did not address questions raised by members on law and order, and other key issues. "During the Emergency, former CM Stalin was assaulted and his jaw was fractured. Body shaming or making derogatory remarks about someone's appearance is condemnable," he said. **S VIJAY KARTHIK**

{ **INTERVIEW** } SACHIN PILOT, CONGRESS'S PUNJAB IN-CHARGE

'Channi assured he will support party's efforts'

Saubhadra Chatterji

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NEW DELHI: Congress general secretary Sachin Pilot, who was recently appointed in-charge of Punjab, maintains that all senior party leaders in the state have assured him to work unitedly ahead of the crucial assembly polls. In an interview to HT, the AICC member talks about his new role as well as the party's prospects in the upcoming Punjab polls. Edited excerpts:

The Congress in Punjab faces sharp divisions between Charanjit Singh Channi and Amrinder Singh Raja Warring.

Punjab is very important not just for the Congress but for the country. This state is very dear to all of us including the Congress leadership. I have already met most of the top leaders in Punjab. They have assured that they will work unitedly. It will be my duty and responsibility to ensure that every leader and worker feels that he or she is a stakeholder in the collective future of the Punjab Congress.

Of course, there are minor differences of opinion. But we will fight this election with Mr Rahul Gandhi, the one person who has captured the imagination of the youth and all thinking people. It's clear that Rahul and Priyanka Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge will lead the campaign. And everybody else in Punjab who has really toiled for the last one and a half years will be a major support to our effort when we lead the campaign.

Have you met Channi?

As I said, I have spoken to almost all the key leaders. All of them have assured me they will work collectively to deliver results



under the leadership of Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge. People of Punjab want the Congress to be there. All of us want the Congress to win. I had a cordial meeting with Channi and he has assured me that he will offer his full support to the party's efforts for the election. Please remember, the Congress had made him the only Dalit chief minister of Punjab. He remembers what Rahul Gandhi had done for him. In our meeting, he was very candid and assured that he will work shoulder to shoulder with the top leadership of the Punjab Congress.

You are set to face AAP, a possible coalition between Shiromani Akali Dal and BJP, and smaller outfits. How do you see it?

It will certainly be a multi-cornered election but the main contest will be between the Congress and the AAP. Of course, there is BSP, BJP, the two factions of the Akali Dal and some other smaller parties. But people of Punjab are looking for a stable alternative. It's a border state and people know that religious divides or geographical disparities must not come in the way of giving a solid mandate. We also feel what the BJP has done in Delhi it was an open display of being anti-young people and anti-students. So, there's a narrative now and I think Rahul Gandhi is at the forefront of that. Also, BJP

doesn't have a very strong footing in Punjab. They have been a junior ally of the Akali Dal. And even when they were together, they have lost many elections.

In the last polls, the Congress won just two of the 69 seats in Malwa region. Channi himself lost both his seats. And there is a demand for a stronger Jatt Sikh leader.

When any party is in government, going into polls, person heading the government becomes a face. But as the opposition, it can't just be one or two people. It has to be a full team. Look, Channi was given a chance towards the end of the term and he tried his best. I don't want to use the last election as a benchmark. It was a wave election where a lot of people perhaps won who weren't deserving. This election will see a fair decision.

AAP was untested and people gave them an opportunity. But in the last four and a half years, the AAP government has only served the interest of the party leadership. Today it is marred by controversies, arrests and corruption scandals. The Congress had a very good performance in the Lok Sabha elections, which indicates that the people want change.

What is Rahul Gandhi's message to you?

His consistent message is that we have to work for the people of Punjab. The voters of Punjab expect the Congress party to live up to their expectation. He's asked me to work on the ground and spend time in Punjab. He's very keen to start his yatra as soon as possible. Our teams are working to finalise the details of how to do it. Rahul and Priyanka Gandhi want the party in Punjab to work tirelessly, unitedly, collectively for the party and for the state.

File FIR against Vijayan, kin in CMRL case, ED writes to DGP

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KOCHI/NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate has written to the Kerala DGP seeking an FIR against former chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter Veena T, and son-in-law PA Mohammed Riyas and some others in connection with the CMRL-linked alleged bribery case, people familiar with the matter said on Tuesday.

The federal agency sent a communication under section 66 (2) of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) citing findings from its investigation in the case, the people said.

This section under the anti-money laundering law empowers ED to share findings of its criminal investigation with a law enforcement agency for registration of a fresh FIR or complaint. ED can book a PMLA case based on such a police case.

ED has sought registration of a police FIR from the Kerala DGP against Vijayan, Veena, her husband and former minister Riyas and some others under the provisions of the Prevention of Corruption Act and other laws on the



Pinarayi Vijayan

basis of "evidence" recovered during its probe and searches conducted in this case under the PMLA, the people cited above said. It is alleged by ED that Kerala mining firm Cochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd (CMRL) made fraudulent payments worth ₹2.78 crore to Veena's now-defunct company Exalogic Solutions under the guise of 'IT consultancy services'.

The agency raided Veena, who was living with Vijayan at a rented accommodation in Thiruvananthapuram, in June and subsequently questioned her.

It had said in a statement in August that some "handwritten" notes were seized during searches against Veena and these contained details of certain fund transfers to Dubai.

Earlier in the day, Riyas said that neither he nor Veena and

Vijayan are afraid of any kind of investigation against them.

Talking to reporters, Riyas, who is also an MLA from Bepore, said they will face the investigation legally. "Any kind of investigation can be carried out. None of us have done any wrong. There is no need for us to be afraid. The innocent shall remain innocent no matter what kind of probe is carried out," the former minister contended.

He also claimed that the political motives behind the ED action had already been revealed before everyone. "No kind of investigation will affect us in any way. So, we are not scared. Let the UDF government decide what it wants to do. Every kind of probe will prove our innocence," he said.

Earlier, Vijayan had called the ED case against his daughter a political vendetta.

Meanwhile, Kerala home minister Ramesh Chennithala said the government was bound to take legal action on the ED's letter seeking an FIR.

"The government is bound to take the legally required action. This is a letter given after the ED has already conducted a probe," the minister said.

FIR filed in U'khand 'purification' ritual

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DEHRADUN/HALDWANI: An FIR has been registered against an unidentified person in Uttarakhand's Haldwani for allegedly conducting a "purification" ritual at a public ground following an event attended by Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge last month, and circulating an allegedly doctored video aimed at inciting communal and caste-based enmity, officials said on Tuesday.

The case was lodged at the Haldwani police station in Nainital district on Monday, based on a complaint submitted by Anju (who goes by her first name), a local advocate and social worker.

"The case has been lodged against one unidentified individual. If more people are identified during the probe, their names will be added to the FIR," superintendent of police (city) Manoj Katyaj said.

According to the complaint, Kharge attended a Congress event at Ramilla Maidan in Haldwani on August 8. Two days later, on August 10, individuals allegedly associated with the BJP conducted a public "purification" of the venue, and later shared photos and video clips of the act on social media, it alleged.

The complainant further alleged that as Kharge belongs to a Scheduled Caste community, conducting such a ritual immediately following his visit prima facie represents caste-based discrimination, public humiliation, and an attempt to demean a member of the community.

The complainant also said that



Mallikarjun Kharge

an "edited" video was circulated online purportedly displaying controversial religious slogans to generate hostility toward a specific community, disrupt public harmony, and vitiate the local political atmosphere. The complaint called for forensic analysis to trace the origin, original audio, editors, and initial uploaders of the clip.

The case has been registered under sections 196 (promoting enmity between different groups) and 299 (deliberate acts to outrage religious feelings) of BNS, along with Section 3(1)(r) of the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act.

Another complaint filed

Meanwhile, a group of Congress leaders led by lawmaker Mallu Ravi sought registration of an FIR against Shri Ram Dhar-marth Seva Nyas president, Girish Chandra Pandey and 15 others over the "purification" ritual.

Lodging a complaint at the Parliament Street police station in Delhi, Ravi alleged that Pandey and others performed a yajna and sprinkled Gangajal at the venue on August 10. "Even after two hours of persuasion by the MPs, the SHO refused to register Zero FIR..." Congress leader K Raju said on X.

HC ALLOWS PVT PLAINT AGAINST KHARGES' TRUST

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka High Court has allowed a private complaint alleging irregularities in the allotment of a civic amenity site in Bengaluru to a trust associated with Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and his family to proceed, rejecting a plea to stop the proceedings.

The dispute concerns an 8,125-sq-m site in Banashankari allotted by the Bengaluru Development Authority (BDA) to the Siddhartha Vijay Trust. The complainant, Vijayraghava Marathe, has alleged violations in the allotment process and questioned a concession that reduced the lease consideration.

Marathe has alleged that the trust claimed Scheduled Caste status while applying for the site and consequently received a 50% concession on the lease amount. He has also alleged collusion between BDA officials and beneficiaries of the allotment. Those named in the complaint have disputed the allegations.

Justice M Nagaprasanna was hearing Marathe's challenge to the Special Court's decision to proceed with the private complaint under Section 223 of the BNS, instead of directing the Lokayukta police to register a case and investigate.

KPC research chairman Dodde Gowda said, "We will obey and honour the law. The trust is doing social service but few people are making false allegations."

Bihar Cong stages protest



Senior Bihar Congress leader Anand Madhab, along with other party leaders and workers, stages a protest in New Delhi on Tuesday, demanding the removal of Bihar unit chief Rajesh Kumar and the party in-charge Krishna Allavaru.

ANI

HC rejects Asaram's temporary bail plea in 2013 rape case

AHMEDABAD: The Gujarat High Court on Tuesday dismissed the plea for temporary bail filed by self-styled godman Asaram.

Asaram, 85, who was convicted and sentenced to life imprisonment by a Gandhinagar court in a 2013 rape case of a minor at his ashram, had sought 20 days of temporary bail, citing a Rajasthan High Court order last month that granted him 20-day parole in a separate rape case.

Meghalaya-Assam taxi standoff ends, tourist travel eased

SHILLONG: A fortnight-long standoff between tourist taxi operators of Meghalaya and Assam following violence last month has ended with both states agreeing to remove operational hurdles and ensure tourist vehicles can move freely across the inter-state border. This came at a joint meeting in Shillong on Tuesday attended by seven associations from Assam and five from Meghalaya.

{ **SPOTTED IN ODISHA FORESTED AREA** }

5 orangutans' rescue raises trafficking fears

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BHUBANESWAR: Five orangutans, typically found in the forests of Southeast Asia, have been rescued from a forested area in coastal Odisha, prompting the state forest and wildlife officials to investigate whether they were being smuggled through an international wildlife trafficking network, people familiar with the matter said.

The orangutans, estimated to be between one and two years old, were found in the Ranakath Protected Reserve Forest near Badapai village of Bhograi block in Baleshwar district, said principal chief conservator of forests (wildlife) Prem Kumar Jha. The place where the orangutans were rescued is less than 100 metres from the coast.

Orangutans are great apes native to parts of Indonesia and Malaysia and are not naturally found in India, the people said.

Odisha forest minister Ganesh Ram Singh Khuntia said the discovery raised suspicions of wildlife trafficking. "It is possi-



The orangutans, estimated to be between one and two years old, were found in the Ranakath Protected Reserve Forest.

HT PHOTO

ble that an international mafia may be involved in trafficking them," Khuntia said, adding that an investigation by an assistant chief conservator of forests has been ordered. An orangutan could fetch around ₹25 lakh in the market.

The orangutans were immediately shifted to the campus of the Udayapur Section Office for continuous observation and treatment by veterinary offi-

cials.

"Orangutans are found in two to three places abroad. The wildlife wing of the forest department is investigating how they came to Odisha..." the PCCF (wildlife) said, adding that the orangutans have been brought to Nandankanan zoo in Bhubaneswar. "Once the animals are brought to Nandankanan zoo in Bhubaneswar, they will remain in quarantine

before further decisions are taken about their care."

In November 2024, an orangutan and several reptiles were rescued from a rented flat in Dombivli town near Mumbai while in October 2023, Customs department in Mizoram rescued a critically endangered baby orangutan suspected to have been smuggled from Myanmar in Seling village of Aizawl district. In September 2022, two baby orangutans, suspected to be smuggled from Assam's Cachar district.

A wildlife expert said the orangutans may have been trafficked through Sumatra, Thailand, Bangladesh and from there Odisha coast through small boats. "The mother orangutan was probably killed by the poachers and then trafficked from Sumatran forests before reaching Bangladesh. From Bangladesh the apes could have been trafficked through small boats to Odisha as they are likely to escape the scanner," said the expert, unwilling to be named.

BJP LEADER BHATIA FILES DEFAMATION SUIT IN HC AGAINST CJP MEMBERS

NEW DELHI: Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader and senior advocate Gaurav Bhatia has filed a defamation suit before the Delhi High Court against Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) spokesperson Saurav Das over his allegedly defamatory post in which he claimed that Bhatia called right wing influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj a "dimagi naxal".

Bhatia's suit, which also names CJP founder Abhijit Dipke and co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka as defendants, and seeks ₹2 crore as damages was filed after Das shared an AI-generated graphic on September 5.

Das later deleted the post after Bhatia's warning. However, Das clarified on X that the graphic was AI-generated and questioned Bhatia on whether he "disagreed" with the statement attributed to him. In his suit, Bhatia said the post was viewed by more than 1,32,000 viewers immediately.

It added that Ranka further amplified the disputed post by reposting it.

SHRUTI KAKKAR

VanDyke, six Ukrainians charged by NIA; no UAPA

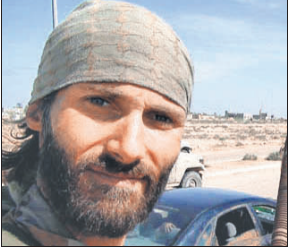
Arnabjit Sur and
Neeraj Chauhan
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NEW DELHI: The National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Tuesday filed a charge sheet against American citizen Mathew Aaron VanDyke and six Ukrainians arrested earlier this year for allegedly training ethnic armed groups in Myanmar, but did not charge them under the stringent Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA).

The agency, however, left the question of UAPA prosecution open, saying that its investigation into the alleged conspiracy was continuing.

The charge sheet, filed before special judge Prashant Sharma at Rouse Avenue Courts, seeks prosecution of the seven under the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025, for allegedly violating the conditions of their entry and stay in India. The court has fixed October 1 for consideration of the charge sheet. All seven are in judicial custody.

"We have filed a charge sheet against seven accused under the Immigration and Foreigners Act. The probe has been kept open in all other aspects, including the UAPA charges," NIA special public prosecutor Rahul Tyagi told HT.



Matthew VanDyke

NIA had initially registered the case on March 13 under Section 18 of UAPA and sections 21 and 23 of the Immigration and Foreigners Act, relating to illegal entry and violations of visa conditions.

VanDyke was arrested at Kolkata airport in March, while the six Ukrainians -- Hurba Petro, Taras Slyviak, Ivan Sukmanovskiy, Marian Stefankiv, Maksim Honcharuk and Viktor Kaminskyi -- were arrested at airports in Delhi and Lucknow. They are currently lodged in Tihar jail.

NIA had alleged that the seven used Indian tourist visas to enter Myanmar illegally through Mizoram on more than one occasion and train ethnic armed groups (EAGs) in drone warfare, drone operations, assembly and jamming technology.

The agency also alleged that

large consignments of drones were imported from Europe.

According to the charge sheet, the seven entered India on valid travel documents in December 2025 before travelling to Guwahati and Mizoram.

"One group comprising Petro Hurba, Taras Slyviak and Ivan Sukmanovskiy travelled from Mumbai to Guwahati and then Mizoram. Another group comprising Marian Stefankiv, Maksim Honcharuk and Viktor Kaminskyi travelled through Delhi and Guwahati. Van Dyke travelled directly from Delhi to Guwahati before joining others," it said.

NIA alleged they then crossed into Myanmar through unauthorised points and reached Victoria Camp, where they were to conduct pre-scheduled training for Myanmar-based EAGs. They allegedly returned to India around March 5, 2026, again through an unauthorised entry point in Mizoram.

The agency has named two people -- Abika and Viktor/Kima -- as alleged facilitators who arranged logistics for the border crossing. It alleged that six taxis were hired to transport the accused from Guwahati into Mizoram's protected area before they crossed into Myanmar through the Tiau river route.

"So far, it appears there is no terror conspiracy against India. We have filed a charge sheet under the Immigration and Foreigners Act as we found robust evidence establishing that these seven individuals violated their entry and stay conditions," an NIA official said on condition of anonymity.

A second officer said investigations were continuing into the alleged links with EAGs associated with anti-India insurgent groups, as well as the role of eight other Ukrainian nationals who had entered India.

The charge sheet, which HT has accessed, states that a "substantial part" of the further investigation into alleged UAPA offences has been completed but more time is required "to ascertain and verify the true and complete facts" relating to those offences.

NIA has sought permission to continue investigating the alleged conspiracy, including the import and recovery of drones and accessories through India and material seized from digital devices.

The NIA said some material recovered from the devices "may indicate their possible involvement in acts affecting/threatening the unity, integrity, security and sovereignty of India".

U'khand to implement DSE/PSE model in SIR

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DEHRADUN: The Demographic Similar Entry/Photo Similar Entry (DSE/PSE) module will be implemented in Uttarakhand as part of the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls to identify possible duplicate or erroneous voter entries, chief electoral officer BVR Purushottam said on Tuesday.

Under the system, electoral-roll entries with similar demographic details or photographs will be flagged for verification.

DSE refers to entries where details such as a voter's name, age, gender or other particulars appear similar to another entry, while PSE identifies records with photographs that appear similar to those in other electoral-roll entries.

Being flagged under the module, however, will not automatically lead to deletion from the electoral roll, the officer said. Voters identified through DSE/PSE will be issued notices and given 15 days to submit their responses, after which their cases will be examined.

Purushottam also held a meeting with representatives of recognised political parties to discuss the ongoing SIR exercise and sought their suggestions. He informed them that the Election Commission of

EC NOTICE TO PADMA AWARDEE RECALLED AFTER VERIFICATION

MANGALURU: Padma Shri awardee Harekala Hajabba, who was issued a notice by the EC during the ongoing SIR of electoral rolls over a mismatch in his name, had the issue resolved after officials verified his documents, the Dakshina Kannada district administration said on Tuesday. Hajabba was served the notice on Monday. He said his name appeared as "Hajabba" in the 2002 electoral roll, while his other official records carry his full name. Deputy commissioner Darshan H said the notice was generated as part of the standard verification process.

KEVIN MENDONSA

India (ECI) had extended the deadline for the final publication of the electoral roll in Uttarakhand to October 3, 2026.

He also said hearings had been completed for more than 24.29 lakh of the 24.30 lakh notices issued to voters over discrepancies and unmapped entries.

The parties were further informed that hearings on more than 40% of claims and objections submitted through Forms 6, 7 and 8 had been completed. Detailed discussions were also held on the SIR process, and suggestions from the parties were sought.

TRIBAL GIRL RAPED IN SHELTER HOME, TWO ARRESTED

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KENDRAPARA (ODISHA): A watchman and a 13-year-old inmate of a government-funded shelter home for the destitute in Odisha's Kendrapara district were taken into custody on Tuesday for allegedly raping a 16-year-old tribal girl from Jharkhand, police said.

The matter came to light when she was found to be four months pregnant.

The victim, who hails from Jharkhand, was rescued by Childline in Kendrapara on June 22, 2023 and lodged at the shelter home by the district Child Welfare Committee (CWC).

Police said she was allegedly sexually assaulted multiple times by the two accused persons during her stay in the shelter home. The 52-year-old watchman was employed at the home while the juvenile was staying at the childcare institute.

"We have arrested the watchman and booked him under sections of BNS and POCSO Act. Further investigation is underway," investigating officer Padmalaya Pradhan said.

IAF TO SHOWCASE DRONE TECH AT DRONATHON-2026

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NEW DELHI: The Indian Air Force will offer domestic manufacturers a platform to demonstrate their drone and counter-drone technologies at Dronathon-2026 to be held at Pokhran range near Jaisalmer from Sept 14 to 16.

"It will help identify contemporary solutions and evaluate their combat effectiveness. Key areas of focus include surveillance and reconnaissance, autonomous operations, swarm technologies, and electronic warfare," the air force said in a statement. The development comes at a time when ongoing conflicts, including the war in West Asia, have shown that drones and counter-drone technologies are central to future warfare.

The event is designed to provide stakeholders an opportunity to witness emerging drone and counter-drone technologies through operational demonstrations, IAF added. "Through such initiatives, the IAF remains committed to building a technologically advanced, indigenous and future ready force," it said.

TMC factions gear up for bypolls amid fight over symbol

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KOLKATA: The two factions of the Trinamool Congress (TMC) are gearing up for their first electoral battle, upcoming bypolls at two West Bengal assembly seats amid uncertainty over who the Election Commission of India (ECI) will grant the right to the party's poll symbol.

EC announced on Monday that bypolls to Murshidabad district's Rejinagar and East Midnapore's Nandigram will be held on October 6 and the results would be announced on October 9. The nominations can be filed between September 9 and 16.

Former state minister Firhad Hakim, once counted among TMC founder Mamata Banerjee's closest aides and now in the Ritabrata Banerjee-led rival group calling itself the "real TMC," said his "party" will contest both seats.

"We are the TMC. We will win both seats," Hakim said.

Akhruzzaman, the chief whip of the same faction in the state assembly said, "Our working committee is scheduled to meet on Thursday to decide both candidates."

Mamata Banerjee loyalists did not comment on candidate selection till Tuesday afternoon, but veteran MLA Sobhandeb Chattopadhyay claimed the Bharatiya Janata Party might use its control over the administration to secure the seats.

"BJP will use the police to control the elections. Our supporters will be beaten up by BJP workers," Chattopadhyay said.

Speaking anonymously, a TMC leader from the Mamata Banerjee faction said fielding a formidable candidate from Nandigram might pose a challenge.

"Sheikh Sufiyan was Banerjee's election agent at Nandigram in



Mamata Banerjee and Ritabrata Banerjee

2021 when she was defeated by Adhikari for the first time and had to contest a bypoll at Bhabanipur to continue as chief minister. Sufiyan is a popular TMC face but he has refused to contest. So has Pabitra Kar, who lost to Adhikari in April," this person added.

The election in both constitutes is expected to be polarising.

Humayun Kabir was the TMC's Bharatpur legislator in Murshidabad district before being suspended in 2025.

"There are only 27-30 % Hindu voters in Rejinagar. The rest are all Muslims. If the other parties reach out to the Hindus, I will obviously seek support from the Muslims," Kabir said.

The Hindu-Muslim ratio in Nandigram is almost the opposite. "People of Nandigram are eager to ensure our victory by a larger margin than Falta. I, too, am a voter in Nandigram," CM Suwendu Adhikari said on Monday after the bypolls were announced.

The BJP won the Falta seat by 109,021 votes. The TMC, which won Falta thrice since 2011, finished fourth in the race.

Political analysts see the bypolls as a contest that could determine the real TMC.

"The symbol is crucial. At the same time, it will be interesting to see if the Left or the Congress can do well, as was noticed in Falta. The results will affect the coming municipal polls in Kolkata and the districts," political columnist Suvasish Maitra said.

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'Modi-Putin meeting to help bolster ties'

Rezaul H Laskar

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NEW DELHI: A meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Russian President Vladimir Putin on the margins of the Brics Summit this week is expected to focus on bolstering economic ties, cooperation in energy, including hydrocarbons and nuclear power and collaboration in technology and critical minerals, a top Kremlin official said on Tuesday.

At the same time, Russia is working to address India's concerns such as a growing imbalance in trade ties and the recruitment of Indian nationals in the Russian military, Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov said while addressing a virtual media briefing from Moscow. Putin and Modi will also discuss global issues, including the West Asia crisis and efforts to end the war with Ukraine, when they meet on Friday, he said.

Putin and Modi, who recently met on the sidelines of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Summit in Kyrgyzstan, have a “very pragmatic” relationship and Russia perceives India as a strategic partner with whom it is of “extreme importance” to develop cooperation in such areas as economic and security ties, Peskov said.

In the field of energy, cooperation is not limited to hydrocarbons



8 KERALAM MLAS
STAGE WALKOUT
FROM NCW MEET

Himanshi Dahiya

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NEW DELHI: Eight women legislators from the Congress's Kerala unit staged a walkout from a National Commission for Women (NCW) workshop, alleging that an event billed as a "capacity building workshop" for women lawmakers turned into a "political platform to further BJP's agenda on the delimitation bill", people aware of the matter said on Tuesday.

The two-day workshop was organised in Faridabad on September 7, where Lok Sabha speaker Om Birla was a chief guest.

Bindu Krishna, a Kerala minister, however, said that matters escalated during Om Birla's address, when they registered their protest as he spoke about women's reservation in the Lok Sabha. "How can a workshop with women legislators be an event for one-sided sermons by the Lok Sabha Speaker? It was politically motivated, and hence we decided to walk out," she said.

Responding to the walkout, BJP spokesperson Shazia Ilmi said, "Everybody knows that the Congress is against women... We are only doing what is logical and necessary." HT reached out to NCW for a comment but did not receive a response.

SC GRANTS RAJPAL
YADAV, WIFE RELIEF
ON ₹5-CR DEPOSIT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday exempted actor Rajpal Yadav and his wife from surrendering in seven cheque bounce cases subject to deposit of ₹5 crore with the court registry within 24 hours. The top court granted conditional relief because the deadline for surrender was expiring on September 10.

The Delhi HC had on July 10 sentenced Yadav and his wife to three months imprisonment in seven cheque bounce cases. However, the HC allowed Yadav two months to challenge the order before the SC.

A bench headed by CJI Surya Kant said, "Subject to deposit of ₹5 crore by the petitioners with the registry of this court by tomorrow, they are granted exemption from surrendering."

HTC

Indian, Chinese military commanders
met twice on both sides of border: MEA

Rezaul H Laskar

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NEW DELHI: Top Indian and Chinese military commanders met for the first time in the Arunachal Pradesh sector during two sessions held on both sides of the border this week as a follow-up to recent meetings of the Special Representatives and a border mechanism, the external affairs ministry said on Tuesday.

The first session of the flag meeting between the senior military commanders was held on the Indian side on Sunday and the second session on the Chinese side on Monday, external affairs ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal told a regular media briefing. He did not go into the details of the discussions between the military officials.

The military talks focused on issues along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in the eastern sec-

FIRST SESSION OF
THE FLAG MEETING
WAS HELD ON THE
INDIAN SIDE ON
SUNDAY AND THE
SECOND SESSION
ON THE CHINESE
SIDE ON MONDAY

tor, including maintaining peace and tranquillity along the frontier, people familiar with the matter said. Lt Gen Girish Kalia, who heads the Dimapur-based 3 Corps, led the Indian side.

The Indian army has not commented on the talks.

The 24th round of talks between the Special Representatives - India's National Security Adviser Ajit Doval and Chinese foreign minister Wang Yi - in New Delhi on August 19 had resulted in 10 points of consen-

sus, including creating mechanisms for talks between military commanders in the eastern and middle sectors of the LAC.

"Pursuant to the understandings reached between the Special Representatives of India and China in August 2025 and August 2026 and subsequent discussions at the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination (WMCC), meetings of which were held in Beijing and New Delhi in May and August 2026 respectively, the first senior highest military commander-level flag meeting was held at Wacha on the Indian side in Arunachal Pradesh on September 6 and in Damai on the Chinese side on September 7," Jaiswal said at the media briefing.

He noted that a similar mechanism for talks between military commanders already exists in the western sector, which includes Ladakh. A military face-off between India and China in the

western sector, which began in April-May 2020 and dragged on for more than four years, had taken bilateral ties to their lowest point in six decades. Since the two sides reached an understanding in October 2024 on ending the stand-off, they have taken a number of steps to normalise the relationship and put in place confidence-building measures along the LAC.

It is not usual for Indian and Chinese military commanders to hold talks on both sides of the border, and discussions in the western sector are usually held alternatively on either side of the LAC.

People familiar with the matter said the talks in the Arunachal Pradesh sector were held over two days. This week's meeting was the first since tensions erupted between the Indian Army and the People's Liberation Army (PLA) at Taksing, in Arunachal Pradesh's Upper Subansiri district, in July and August.

FINISH TRIBUNALS'
APPOINTMENTS
UNDER NEW ACT: SC

Abraham Thomas

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed the Centre to ensure appointment to all tribunals under the newly enacted Tribunals Reforms Act 2026 is carried out at the earliest after the government said that 248 members currently serving in 16 tribunals were found eligible to continue in service.

The bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said, "We are concerned about the practical aspect that the tribunal will become defunct during the transitional period."

To ensure the day-to-day functioning of the National Green Tribunal (NGT) is not affected, the court directed the Centre to extend the tenure of three members - two judicial and one technical expert - till such time the new appointment to their posts under the 2026 act is made.

Expert panel to curb unethical
pharma marketing: Govt to SC

Utkarsh Anand

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NEW DELHI: The Centre has decided to constitute a three-member expert committee to examine whether pharmaceutical companies need to be brought under a legally enforceable framework to prevent unethical marketing practices, the government told the Supreme Court on Tuesday.

The decision was disclosed in an affidavit filed before the apex court, which is hearing a petition by the Federation of Medical and Sales Representatives' Associations of India (FMSRAI) seeking a legally binding mechanism to regulate pharmaceutical marketing and unethical conduct by medical professionals.

A bench of justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta considered the affidavit and reserved its order. The Centre said the existing Uniform Code for Pharmaceutical Marketing Practices (UCPMP), 2024 was functioning satisfactorily, particularly in reg-



The SC bench considered the affidavit and reserved its order.

ulating unethical practices by medical practitioners. However, it acknowledged a gap in specifically regulating pharmaceutical companies and decided to constitute the panel to examine whether a statutory framework is required and, if so, what form it should take.

FMSRAI's petition has highlighted alleged use of high-pressure tactics, expensive gifts, foreign trips and other "freebies" by pharmaceutical companies to influence doctors to prescribe irrational drug combinations or expensive branded medicines.

The Centre said attempts between 2013 and 2018 to give

statutory backing to the pharma marketing code raised questions over jurisdiction and legal enforceability. It also examined using the Essential Commodities Act, 1955 and the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940, but found neither law to be an obvious fit.

The government said the Drugs and Cosmetics Act primarily regulates the manufacture, quality and sale of medicines, while the Essential Commodities Act deals with their supply, distribution and prices.

A high-level committee headed by Dr VK Paul, constituted in September 2022, had recommended strengthening the existing voluntary framework rather than making it statutory at that stage. This led to the UCPMP, 2024, which introduced greater disclosure requirements, an Ethics Committee for Pharma Marketing Practice and stricter provisions on gifts, physician samples and continuing medical education. The UCPMP will continue to apply until the proposed committee submits its report.

ANI moves HC division
bench in OpenAI case

Shruti Kakkar

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NEW DELHI: News agency ANI has moved a division bench of the Delhi high court against a single judge's order dismissing its plea to restrain OpenAI from using its content to train ChatGPT.

ANI's appeal against the July 24 verdict was listed before a bench of justices V Kameshwar Rao and Manmeet PS Arora. However, it was adjourned to September 14 as the bench did not assemble.

On July 24, Justice Amit Bansal dismissed ANI's plea, holding that OpenAI's use of the news agency's material for training its large language model (LLM) fell within the statutory exception of "fair dealing" under Indian copyright law.

The judge said the use qualified as "private use" under Section 52(1)(a) of the Copyright Act, 1957. The provision permits fair dealing of copyrighted material for private or personal



Matter adjourned to Sept 14.

use, including research, criticism, review and reporting of current events.

Justice Bansal, in his 135-page verdict, reasoned that the training data was accessible only to the AI model during the learning process and was not made available to the public for viewing or downloading.

ANI, in its appeal, argued that the injunction was denied without adequately considering OpenAI's alleged admission that it had scraped, stored and commercially exploited the agency's work. The agency contended that such acts infringed its exclusive rights under the Copyright Act, including the rights to store, reproduce, adapt and translate its original works.

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SC-ILLEGAL BUILDINGS

Court, the bench disagreed.
“No. This might have been taken up in the right earnest but it is overlapping. We will take it up. We already have something in mind,” responded the bench. Senior advocate Ajit Kumar Sinha, the court-appointed amicus curiae, told the bench that the latest status report highlighted the Satya Niketan tragedy and sought urgent directions as the inspection exercise ordered by the Supreme Court was already underway. Sinha is assisted by advocate-on-record Govind Jee.

The court said it would hear the matter on Thursday and indicated that it could subsequently consider transferring the proceedings pending before it into the Supreme Court.

The development assumes significance as the Supreme Court’s existing exercise, initiated against the backdrop of widespread violations of building bye-laws and land-use regulations in Delhi, had so far focussed on areas including Lajpat Nagar, Saket and Malviya Nagar. Satya Niketan was not among the localities covered by the inspection.

The amicus has now urged the court to extend the exercise across Delhi, particularly to student accommodation located around universities and colleges, where residential properties are frequently used as PGs or private hostels and may have undergone unauthorised additions or changes in use.

The latest status report records that a multi-storeyed building at P-14, Satya Niketan, collapsed on September 6. The property, spread over around 55 square yards, had a basement and four floors above the ground and was being used as a boys’ PG under the name Hostel Daze. Seven people were killed and at least 12 rescued.

The precise cause of the collapse is still under investigation, though preliminary material has indicated construction-related work in or around the basement and waterlogging immediately before the incident.

The amicus has proposed a time-bound inspection and safety audit of PGs, private hostels and similar student accommodation facilities across Delhi. The audit would examine sanctioned building plans against actual construction, the number of floors, basement construc-

tion and alterations, permissible land use, structural safety and fire-safety compliance, means of ingress and egress and whether the premises are in a dangerous or ruinous condition.

The report has also pointed to the recurrence of building collapses in Satya Niketan, noting that another building collapse in the locality in April 2022 had killed two people and injured four. It has questioned whether the existing system for inspecting buildings, identifying dangerous structures and enforcing building regulations is adequate to prevent such tragedies.

The urgency of the proposed expansion has also been underlined by the MCD’s action against an adjoining property at P-13, Satya Niketan, which it found to be in a dangerous condition. The civic body ordered demolition of the structure on September 6. Five MCD officials from the South Zone have also been suspended in connection with the tragedy.

The Supreme Court’s intervention comes alongside separate proceedings before the Delhi High Court, which on Monday directed the MCD to inspect within a week all PG hostels under its jurisdiction and ascertain whether they had been constructed with requisite permissions and whether there were violations of building bye-laws.

A bench of chief justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia also ordered an inquiry at the highest executive level into the Satya Niketan collapse and directed the MCD to identify officials responsible for any regulatory lapses. The high court had observed that responsibility for such mishaps did not prima facie lie only with the owner of the PG but also extended to university authorities and the MCD, which is responsible for ensuring that construction and development in Delhi complies with applicable building regulations.

The amicus has nevertheless placed the tragedy in the context of the larger Supreme Court proceedings, which began after the top court took note of widespread and blatant violations of building bye-laws and land-use regulations, including construction in prohibited areas and subsequent use of properties for purposes other than those for which they were sanctioned.

The court had in March indicated that the problem war-

ranted monitoring on a pan-India basis and subsequently ordered an inspection of buildings in selected Delhi localities. That inspection was completed on September 3 and the committee is understood to have found certain buildings in Said-ulajab, Saket and Lajpat Nagar to be in precarious or unsafe condition. Its report is expected to be placed before the Supreme Court shortly.

Against this backdrop, the amicus has asked the court to ensure that the inspection does not remain confined to a handful of localities but extends to establishments housing students, particularly around Delhi’s universities and colleges.

The request puts the spotlight once again on the gap between permissions on paper and the manner in which buildings are actually constructed and used in the national capital.

PM ON INDIA’S GROWTH

and finally inaugurating the Global Fintech Fest 2026 in Mumbai. Modi said the world was passing through a period of conflict, uncertainty, energy and commodity challenges, and trade tensions, making India’s 7.8% GDP growth in the previous quarter particularly significant. He said the growing global confidence in India was also reflected in sovereign ratings.

“Such developments showed that the world was confident about India’s growth momentum, macroeconomic stability and structural reforms. The country’s fintech story would remain incomplete without UPI, which has completed 10 years. What appeared impossible a decade ago has become a daily reality for millions of Indians,” he said.

He also called on the fintech industry to strengthen cybersecurity, adopt ethical data-protection standards, deepen regulator-industry innovation and develop a fintech consumer protection index for transparent company ratings.

Earlier in the day, he took a dig at the Opposition over the newly inaugurated dedicated freight corridor, saying critics would still complain like a “naraz fufa” (grumpy uncle) and manufacture grievances, while also dismissing Congress leader Rahul Gandhi’s campaign against the government as “jhooth ki goonj” (echo of lies).

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

Speaking at the inauguration of three key sections of the Western Dedicated Freight Corridor, connecting Jawaharlal Nehru Port in Navi Mumbai with Dadri in Uttar Pradesh, Modi praised his administration’s pace of execution and called the former Congress-led UPA regime’s working speed sluggish.

“After 2014, with your blessings, when I reached Delhi, and as soon as we arrived there, we began accelerating this project. Work on the dedicated freight corridor has been completed today,” Modi said.

Targeting Congress leader Rahul Gandhi without naming him, Modi said that opponents would always find fault with major infrastructure milestones.

“Now, the naraz fufaji (grumpy uncle) will start shouting: What will happen to the truck drivers? Where will the trucks go? What about the trucks people have purchased? Now, fufaji has found something new to complain about,” Modi quipped.

Modi pointed to rapid modernisation under his tenure.

“After 2014, India built 50,000 modern rail coaches. The previous regime could not build even 50,000 toilets in 10 years,” he said, reiterating that the nation’s youth would continue to champion reality over political rhetoric.

Taking aim at the Opposition’s outreach efforts, specifically Gandhi’s ‘Chhatron Ki Goonj’ campaign, the PM cautioned the youth.

“At every nook and corner, you will find people who will try to mislead you through lies, but today’s youth will stand with the truth,” Modi said.

At MSU Pavilion Ground, the stage was built like that in a concert where a Y-shaped ramp ran off the dais for Modi to walk among Gen-Z students and young professionals. Entry was by free BookMyShow registration. Seats filled in about an hour, some 42,000 were wait-listed, and about 6,000 were inside.

Earlier in the day at Maharaja Sayajirao University grounds, Modi underlined his government’s achievements.

“This dedicated freight corridor stands as a testament to how the country’s work culture has transformed over the last 12 years. The concept for this dedicated freight corridor was first

mooted in 2004... A special company was formed in 2006 to execute this project. Yet, until 2014, the files merely shuttled back and forth; they were just traveling from one table to another. And look at the irony—even these files did not get the benefit of a dedicated corridor,” he said.

“In 2014, the people of Vadodara, Gujarat, and the entire nation sent me from Gujarat to Delhi. The previous government remained in power until 2014, you sent me there, and they were shown the door. In 7-8 years, not even a single kilometre of work on the freight corridor had been completed. Had the country been run according to their methods, who knows, even three or four subsequent generations might have passed without it ever getting done. That was the state in which they had left a project meant to transform India’s logistics ecosystem. After 2014, I set about accelerating this work immediately.”

Modi said that from the Red Fort on Independence Day, he had invoked ‘Saptadharā’ for Viksit Bharat (developed India) and that Gati Shakti was one of the seven streams.

In Mumbai, Modi urged the fintech ecosystem to not rest on the laurels of the past decade that saw real-time payments using UPI rise to 24.51 billion transactions, as of August this year. He said the focus should be to expand UPI to countries that are home to a large Indian diaspora, have high trade volumes with India or are willing to partner with New Delhi in connecting their systems.

“This is essential because Indians work in large numbers in foreign countries. They are the largest remitters of money. A part of the remittances goes away as transaction costs; UPI can help in saving on these costs and the money can also reach families faster,” he said.

Modi said the UPI platform was now live in 11 countries and connected with the local system in Singapore. “We can set our own rules and standards and connect them with the world,” he said.

Reiterating French President Emmanuel Macron’s words, Modi said UPI was not only a tech story but also a civilisational one.

With inputs from G Mohiuddin
Jeddy

RUSSIA ON IRAN, UAE

meet at a time when sharp differences between Iran and the UAE – which are on opposite sides of the West Asia conflict – have impacted preparatory meetings.

Brics Sherpas are currently meeting in New Delhi to finalise the text of the leaders’ declaration to be adopted at the summit and people familiar with the matter said differences remained between Iran and the UAE on the text to refer to the situation in West Asia.

Peskov responded to a question from HT on differences between Iran and the UAE by saying the Russian side is hopeful the Brics member states will be able to come to an agreement on text that satisfies the interests of the two countries. He also said Moscow stands ready to help Iran and the UAE, both friends of Russia, normalise their relations.

“The UAE and Iran – understandably there are contradictions in their positions and understandably they’re now experiencing problems in their bilateral relations,” Peskov said. “We stand for security in the region, we stand for mutual trust and we deny any aggressive actions in the region and we hope that sooner or later the situation will be normalised.”

He added, “You ask if it influences the processes within Brics. Yes, of course, it has a negative impact and it [makes] the work of drafting the papers, the declaration more complicated. But we have very talented diplomats, and we have very talented diplomats on the side of the Indian presidency, and we have no doubt that necessary phrasings will be found to satisfy the national interests of both countries concerned.”

A meeting of Brics foreign ministers in May ended without a joint statement as the differences between Iran and the UAE emerged in the open during testy exchanges between the two sides.

At the conclusion of this meeting, India issued a chair’s statement and an outcome document with two specific paragraphs on which there was no unanimity.

Peskov referred to the three pillars of cooperation within Brics and said there numerous initiatives to take forward collaboration in crucial areas such as security, space, reform of global institutions such as the

UN, food security, technology and AI, including the creation of a “Brics brain exchange”, transportation and connectivity, energy, and healthcare.

“The financial sphere is of great importance. Russia recently reached a level of 90% of all transactions with Brics countries being made in national currencies...It’s not because we are aiming for de-dollarisation or getting rid of US dollars,” Peskov said.

“To the contrary, we’re open to every acceptable method of payment. Certain countries are using some national currencies as a tool for political oppression – they’re introducing sanctions based on their national currencies. So if they don’t let us use their money, we use our own money,” he said, arguing that the US itself is “ruining trust” in the dollar as a reserve currency.

“The more the trust is ruined, the more the trust is going in favour of national currencies...All the countries are doing what is more favourable for them. If it’s more favourable to use national currencies, they will do more and more payments in national currencies,” he said.

Peskov further said that Russia and India are on the same page in rejecting the contention that Brics is anti-West.

Referring to Brics as a “club” without any charter, he said, “Brics is for Brics members and Brics is for those countries who share the Brics ideology. And Brics is not against any third party.”

Besides President Putin, Chinese President Xi Jinping, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian and the leaders of key Brics member states such as South Africa and Egypt are set to attend the summit over the weekend. The outreach session of the summit will be joined by leaders of partner states such as Belarus, Vietnam, Malaysia, Thailand, and Uzbekistan.

Brics originally comprised Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa, and the grouping was expanded in 2024 to include Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, the UAE and Saudi Arabia, while Indonesia joined in 2025. However, Saudi Arabia’s top leadership has not participated in any summit since 2024.

Brics groups 11 emerging economies representing 49.5% of the global population, 40% of global GDP and almost 26% of world trade.

U.S. LABOUR DEPT
SUSPENDS GREEN
CARD FILINGS
BY COGNIZANT

Shashank Mattoo
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WASHINGTON: The US Department of Labour suspended India-founded and US-listed tech giant Cognizant’s ability to file for green card sponsorship on Tuesday, amid an investigation into visa fraud.

“Threats to American workers will NOT be tolerated,” said the Labour Department’s inspector general Anthony D’Esposito in a post on X. Technology firm Cloudera also faced a suspension of its PERM filings.

D’Esposito announced that the company’s PERM filings had been suspended. This refers to the labour certification process that US employers must complete before sponsoring a foreign worker for an employment based green card. Under this process, the US Department of Labour sets a minimum wage that the job must pay, following which the sponsoring firm must advertise domestically for interested applicants to fill the job.

Once a mandatory waiting period is concluded, the firm can proceed with the hiring process.

Acquiring the PERM certification is typically the first step in securing an employment-based green card for a foreign worker.

Cognizant, which was founded in Chennai in 1994 and is now headquartered in the US, is typically one of the largest petitioners for H-1B visas in corporate America. According to figures provided by US Citizenship and Immigration Services, Cognizant has received 3,510 approved H-1B visa petitions thus far in 2026. This places it sixth overall in the US, behind Amazon, TCS, Infosys, Apple and Microsoft.

D’Esposito had hinted at regulatory action against Cognizant some months ago on X. In response to posts by anonymous accounts complaining about visa abuse carried out by the firm, D’Esposito asked users to “stay tuned” using his official Department of Labour handle.

The Trump administration has made combating visa abuse a key policy priority and launched “Project Firewall,” an aggressive enforcement initiative targeting employers who abuse the H-1B visa programme, in September last year.

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OPINION

The
Hindu Times
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{ OUR TAKE }

Draconian decrees can't be the norm

The judiciary must ensure that strict provisions don't become levers of executive overreach

The Allahabad High Court's order quashing the preventive detention of student activist should be read carefully, not just by the Gautam Buddha Nagar administration whose conduct came under sharp censure, but also by bureaucrats and police officers sometimes too eager to signal their political allegiance by slapping draconian provisions on protesters. Against the backdrop of the lower judiciary often slow-peddling politically sensitive cases, the judgment also offers a template for how constitutional courts must treat stringent laws as extraordinary provisions that should be used sparingly and rigorously backed up by evidence, not as a blunt instrument to stymie dissent.

The facts of the case, as laid out by the high court order, are jarring. A notice under Section 130 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, ostensibly issued before the activist's arrest, carried a general diary number that could only have been generated after she was taken into custody. When the shameful fabrication of records was pointed out by the court, the administration had no answer. The bench also found that the WhatsApp messages and videos did not contain "a single message" or video showing that the activist incited people to riot. Such inconsistencies prompted the high court to rebuke district magistrate Medha Roopam, saying that her conduct was "worthy of derision" and that she likely violated her oath of office by trying to make an "example" out of the activist. It is a damning indictment of a bureaucrat, and should prompt her to course correct, if only to match the dignity of the office she holds.

Beyond the particulars of the case, unfortunate as they are, the verdict holds wider lessons. Far too often, courts shy away from imposing accountability on erring bureaucrats and police officers — even in this case, the lower courts rubber-stamped the detention. This should not be the norm, and the judiciary must ensure that strict provisions don't become levers of executive overreach. In warning that some officers who forget their oath to the Constitution risk reducing Uttar Pradesh to "an Orwellian Dystopia", the court has underlined a disturbing trend among senior officers to privilege narrow career and political concerns over the demands of the country's founding document. It is a shame that a constitutional court had to use a global totem for repression and authoritarianism to describe the conduct of officers in charge of governing the world's largest democracy. It cannot be allowed again.

An invitation to tango on the Moon

The US has been courting India about setting up a joint lunar base. A month after Nasa's invitation to Isro, US ambassador to India Sergio Gor reiterated the intent. This is undoubtedly a recognition of both Isro's repertoire of skills across a range of space operations as well as India's growing ambitions as a space leader.

Over the decades, Isro has demonstrated superior technological and operational ability that has, at times, even surpassed Nasa's. Chandrayaan-3's remains the world's only soft landing on the lunar South Pole, a notoriously difficult and, thus, largely unexplored terrain. This seems particularly important for the US's Moon base plans given its first phase envisages robotic missions to the lunar South Pole that demonstrate technological soundness and establish the foundations of a sustained presence. Isro's almost legendary bootstrapping skills, born out of necessity, is one of the strengths Nasa may be looking to harness.

Given India is a signatory to the US-led Artemis Accords, a set of principles for civil exploration of space and bodies such as the Moon and Mars as well as their use, there is a template for the kind of collaboration the US is proposing. This partnership may emerge in accordance with the guidelines on interoperability and open scientific data. There could be certain strategic advantages in locking step with one of the two top space powers amid the new space race. China, too, is eyeing its own lunar mission, with a permanent base and robotic and human landings by 2030. While much of this collaboration appears positive, India needs to consider the invitation — coming at a time when Isro is trying to assuage employee angst over privatisation fears — keeping in mind its own priorities and autonomy. Travelling together cannot come at the cost of becoming the side act to a competitor.

Semicon 2.0 gets it right on the issues that matter

The improvements over Semicon 1.0 reflect the government's commitment to growing India's presence in this sector. The largest risk is the administrative load

On August 31, the ministry of electronics and information technology (MEITY) notified Semicon 2.0, an overhaul of India's semiconductor incentive architecture. Four things stand out. Chip design, for the first time, is front and centre in the scheme rather than an afterthought, a sensible bet given India's real comparative advantage in design talent. Second, the India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) now runs design as well as manufacturing. Until now, design was with the Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC). Third, research and talent development now get specified fiscal backing. Fourth, upfront capex support across manufacturing categories has been recalibrated into a narrower band, mostly 30-40%, down from Semicon 1.0's uniform 50%.

Semicon 1.0 arrived in 2021 as four separate notifications: a design-linked incentive, a compound-semiconductor and packaging scheme, a display-fab scheme, and a silicon-fab scheme. Semicon 2.0 folds the whole value

chain into one instrument with six pillars and 10 categories, spanning design, materials, fabrication, packaging, research and talent.

Semicon 1.0's design-linked incentive worked through reimbursement. Chip design firms spent money, then claimed back up to half, capped at ₹15 crore. They could also claim a deployment incentive on total sales. It did not match the interests of an industry where gestation periods can be as long as five years. As a result, only 24 of a target of 100 firms received the fiscal support.

Semicon 2.0 replaces this scheme with a hybrid capital stack. There's seed funding up to ₹15 crore, and beyond that, equity co-investment or royalty financing once a startup has already raised private venture capital. In other words, startups now have grant, equity and royalty options instead of a single reimbursement route, a mix far better suited to an industry where products can take five years to reach the market. The scheme also drops the earlier numeric cap on foreign shareholding, replacing it with a qualitative requirement that the company remain owned and controlled by Indian citizens or Overseas Citizens of India. Indian startups can also bid in consortium mode with global companies, R&D organisations, and academic institutions.

The removal of the foreign-shareholding cap is a welcome move, but the replacement, a control test rather than

a percentage test, still retains the uncertainty. An eligible startup can raise as much foreign capital as investors are willing to put in, but only up to the point where citizens or OCIs still control the company. This is a reasonable compromise between attracting capital and avoiding a foreign-controlled recipient of public money, but it stops short of a fuller reform. Ideally, support would go to any India-registered company regardless of ownership, since design capability matters more than who holds the equity.

The equity model raises a second problem that will surface once startups start failing, which most will. Venture investing assumes that most bets fail outright and a few big wins cover the rest. Government finance treats the loss of public money as a presumption of impropriety.

Bureaucrats negotiating valuations and write-downs under that scrutiny will be structurally biased toward caution, the opposite of what deep-tech investing needs. One fix is for the State to hold equity with no say in company decisions, leaving private investors to negotiate the actual terms. Whether ISM does something similar will only be clear once guidelines are published.

For defence and critical-infrastructure chips such as telecom, there is a separate category of incentives. C-DAC will select firms via competitive bidding, and the resulting intellectual property be co-owned with C-DAC.



Pranay Kotasthane

Pakistan's lies starting to show in PoK crackdown

The crackdown by Pakistani security forces on peaceful protests in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) has resulted in more than 90 deaths since June this year. Against the background of escalating violence, the 12th Assembly elections were held in the territory. The Pakistan Muslim League (Nawaz), or PML(N), won the majority with seats in the 53-member house and has elected Barrister Iftikhar Gilani as the region's next prime minister (PM). The electoral outcome, however, lacks credibility. The Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC), which was leading the agitation for reform of the electoral system, was declared a terrorist organisation and banned. JAAC, in turn, issued a call for boycott of the elections. The election for seven seats was postponed as the situation continued to be tense.

The people of the region are demanding the abolition of refugee seats in the territory's legislature. Out of a total of 53 seats in the State legislature, 12 are allocated to Kashmiri refugees, and eight are reserved for women and technocrats. Interestingly, the refugees for whom the seats are reserved are residents of Pakistan, not PoK. Permitting them to vote erodes the distinction between the people of PoK and Pakistanis. The small size of the electorate spread over entire expanse of Pakistan makes it easy to manipulate the results. An index of size is the fact that the total number of votes cast in the "refugee" seats representing Kashmir Valley ranged from 1,839 votes (LA 43) to 4,271 votes (LA 45). The results in these constituencies are essentially decided by the ruling party. They give Islamabad a captive block of up to 25% of seats in the PoK legislature with which to influence government formation. This ensures the happy outcome that the government in PoK is invariably formed by the party in power in Islamabad. This is what the protesters are agitating against. The victory of PML(N) in the recent elections has validated their apprehension.

Though the election was held in three stages, the outcome had become clear after the second stage, on August 2, itself. PML(N) gained a majority in the legislature by winning 23 out of 45 elected seats. The ruling party won by bagging 10 out of 12 refugee seats, while the Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) got two seats. Since then, PML (N) has added to its victory margin by winning six out of the eight seats reserved for women, techno-

crats and overseas Pakistanis, while PPP got only two of these seats. There has been a tremendous surge in the PML(N)'s fortune in PoK since it came to power at the federal level. As against six seats in the last PoK assembly elections in 2021, PML(N) won 31 seats this time. The Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI), which won 31 seats last time, is banned and could not contest.

There has been a complete eclipse of the fortunes of PoK-based regional parties. The territory is ruled by Pakistan's mainstream parties such as the PPP, the PML(N), and the PTI. During the last elections, the regional parties had won just two seats. This time, they got none. Contrast this with the situation in Jammu & Kashmir (J&K), which has been ruled by either the J&K National Conference or the Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) for decades. There is no scope for *Kashmiriyat* in PoK.

There are a total of 4,64,000 "Kashmiri" refugees in Pakistan. Of these, only 30,000 are supposed to be from the Kashmir Valley, while 4,34,000 are from Jammu. PoK's total population is 3.2 million. Thus, the Kashmiris living in Pakistan are less than 1% of PoK's population. Their over-representation in the legislative assembly is to maintain the fiction that Pakistan, or PoK, represents the Kashmiri cause. It also distorts any democratic mandate for the region by giving the ruling party at the federal level undue advantage.

Pakistan's response to the protesters' demands has been repeated firings. Defence minister Khwaja Asif said that the people of Mirpur and Rawalkot, where the agitation started, are not Kashmiris. Ironically, in the past, Pakistan has used Mirpuris to highlight its narrative on Kashmir. But when they raise their legitimate demand for democratic representation, Islamabad denies them even their identity. Khwaja Asif went further and described them as enemies of Pakistan, equating them with India.

The PoK Supreme Court said that the "reserved seats" are part of PoK's Constitution. They cannot be abolished by political agitation or negotiation, and require a constitutional amendment. The catch is that under PoK's Constitution, any amendment is subject to Pakistan's veto. The people of PoK have reached a cul-de-sac.

PPP leader Bilawal Bhutto described the polls as "rigged, violent and bloody." He was careful not to attack the system of refugee seats, which is part of the Interim Constitution Act of 1974 adopted under his grandfather, Zulfikar Ali Bhutto. Nawaz Sharif "nominated" Barrister Iftikhar Gilani as the next PM of the territory.

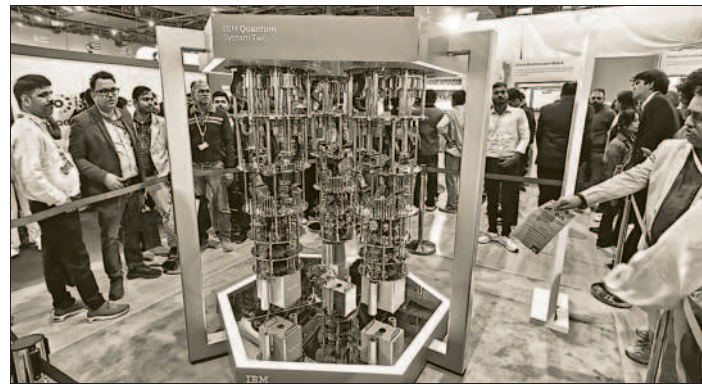
The decision has sparked controversy within his party itself as, earlier, Shah Ghulam Qadir — the party president in PoK — was nominated for the post by Nawaz Sharif. Besides, Gilani contested and lost the Muzaffarabad seat in the recent elections, and then made a back-door entry to the legislature by winning a reserved seat for technocrats. Why did the PML(N) leadership reverse its earlier decision?

There are obviously higher forces who decide. Meanwhile, the people of PoK continue to struggle for *azaadi* (freedom) from Pakistan's control.

DP Srivastava is a former ambassador and the author of *Forgotten Kashmir: The Other Side of the Line of Control*. The views expressed are personal



The people of PoK continue to struggle for *azaadi* from Pakistan's control. AFP



ISM now runs the entire value chain, ten categories, equity management, royalty tracking, and investment decisions. GETTY IMAGES

Co-owning intellectual property with C-DAC is meant to keep sovereign IP out of foreign hands, and to counter export-control blockades. But global venture capital underwrites its bets on unencumbered IP, and a State co-owner makes it nearly non-fundable by private investors. In practice, this category will likely stay the preserve of defence contractors and State-backed consortia. Since C-DAC runs the bidding and ends up co-owning what it selects, the conflict of interest remains.

Pillar 2 is meant for raw materials and equipment used in a fabrication facility. This is an acknowledgement that the inputs feeding chip manufacturing needed a funding line of their own. It offers 30% capex support plus a production-linked incentive of 2-10% on domestic bill-of-materials sourcing from FY29, funding the ultra-pure supply chain fabs previously lacked.

Pillar 3 carries fab support forward with the quantum trimmed. Future silicon wafer fabs now get 40% upfront capital against the earlier 50%, while compound-semiconductor, photonics and display fabs get a lower 35%.

Pillar 4, packaging, is the more interesting one, receiving a graded support at 35% upfront capital support for

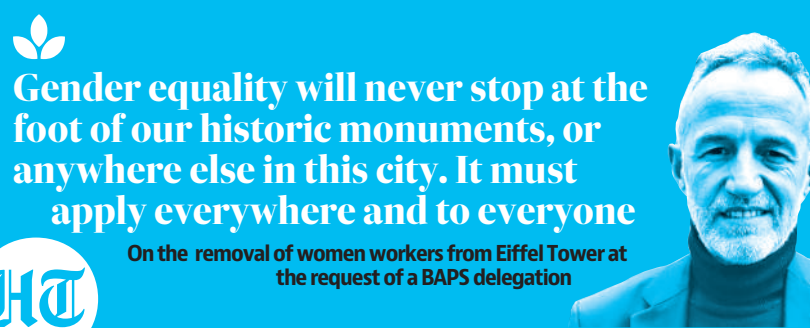
advanced 2.5D and 3D packaging against 25% for legacy work. This plays to a comparative advantage too because nine assembly and testing plants are already approved under Semicon 1.0. Moreover, packaging is becoming more research-intensive to squeeze higher performances.

The two pillars that matter most are research and talent. India's public labs have historically received capital grants for expensive equipment, then no operating budget to run it. Semicon 2.0 funds up to 75% of both. This scheme fixes a structural gap.

Overall, this is a definite improvement over Semicon 1.0 and reflects that the government is firmly committed to growing India's presence in this sector. The largest risk, though, is the administrative load. ISM now runs the entire value chain, ten categories, equity management, royalty tracking, and investment decisions. Whether it works will depend on a step-jump in the capacity of the ministry and ISM to govern this complex mission.

Pranay Kotasthane is a researcher with the high-tech geopolitics programme at the Takshashila Institution. The views expressed are personal

{ EMMANUEL GRÉGOIRE } MAYOR, PARIS, FRANCE



Gender equality will never stop at the foot of our historic monuments, or anywhere else in this city. It must apply everywhere and to everyone

On the removal of women workers from Eiffel Tower at the request of a BAPS delegation

Caesarean deliveries' rising numbers may not be all bad

My first encounter with maternity care was in the sugarcane belt of rural Maharashtra, in the year 2000. I had conducted 18 deliveries at a primary health centre over one year. This was not even a tenth of the childbirths that had occurred at home that year. As was confirmed by the second round of the National Family Health Survey (NFHS-2), childbirth in rural Maharashtra mostly happened at home. Hospitals were sought only when events had already gone wrong. In the past 25 years, with expansion of health care services, government incentives and the growing recognition that medically unsupervised births can become life-threatening, today, more than 90% of births occur in institutions. Over the same period, infant mortality has fallen from about 66 to 24 per 1,000 births, neonatal mortality from 44 to 18 per 1,000 and maternal mortality from nearly 400 to below 100 per 100,000 live births. As childbirth has moved into hospitals, caesarean birth has become steadily more common. Nationally, the rate has risen from 7.1% in 1998 to about 41% in 2024. In the private sector, the figure now approaches 57%.

One reading of this rise in caesareans is that it's evidence of excessive intervention by obstetricians. But the population giving birth today is not the population that was giving birth 25 years ago. Women are having their first child later. They are, on average, heavier, more likely to have metabolic disease, and more likely to conceive with the help of assisted reproduction. These factors alter the risks of labour.

At the hospital where I now work, the mean age at delivery is 33.4 years. NFHS-6 figures suggest women aged 35-49 years are approximately twice as likely to undergo a caesarean delivery as women aged 15-24 years. Similarly, caesarean rates were approximately 35% among women with 12 or more years of schooling, compared with 8% among women with no schooling.

Some 57% of Indian women now exceed the waist-circumference threshold associated with metabolic risk. An overweight woman has approximately twice the odds of caesarean delivery as an underweight woman. Prevalence of hypertension and diabetes has also risen sharply between NFHS-4 and NFHS-5.

This phenomenon is not confined to India or to privately funded health care. In England, where maternity care is predominantly provided through the publicly funded National Health Service (NHS), 45% of births in 2024-25 were by caesarean section. Even the Nordic countries, long held up as evidence that caesarean rates can be kept exceptionally low, have recently crossed 20.5%. This makes the familiar explanation of "greed driven private health care" look insufficient.

There's another issue with the way we have

traditionally spoken about an "optimal" caesarean rate. For decades, the WHO position has been widely understood to mean that once caesarean rates rise beyond roughly 10-15%, the additional operations cease to improve neonatal or maternal mortality at the population level and may therefore represent unnecessary intervention. Neonatal mortality is not the same thing as perinatal or intrapartum mortality. Some of the gravest consequences of a difficult labour never enter the neonatal mortality figures at all. The baby may die before birth, during labour, or shortly afterwards from intrapartum hypoxia and birth asphyxia.

Here, the numbers become uncertain. India doesn't have sufficiently reliable national data on perinatal mortality. Stillbirths and very early neonatal deaths are inconsistently recorded, and the estimates produced by our principal national datasets disagree substantially. NFHS-5 put perinatal mortality at approximately 32 per 1,000 births; the Sample Registration System reported about 18. When two national measures of the same phenomenon differ by almost a factor of two, and the outcome from which we infer an "optimal" caesarean rate fails to adequately capture intrapartum stillbirth, very early neonatal death, and serious neonatal morbidity, then the apparent disappearance of benefit beyond some numerical threshold may be partly an artefact of what has (and hasn't) been measured.

A striking example comes from Australia. A population-level matched cohort study examined more than 867,000 births, comparing standard public maternity care with private obstetric-led care. Caesarean rates remained substantially different: 32% in standard public care versus 48% in private obstetric-led care. But here is the jaw-dropper. The higher caesarean rate in private care was accompanied by substantially fewer adverse neonatal outcomes. Stillbirth or neonatal death was approximately twice as common in standard public care, while neonatal ICU admission was approximately three times as common. Caesarean birth was associated with a 70% reduction in the odds of stillbirth or neonatal death. This study does not prove that more caesareans are always better. But definitely, the relationship between caesarean rates and outcomes is too complex to be contained by a simple population threshold. Perhaps the percentage of caesareans is the wrong place to begin. Shouldn't it be: In which women, under what circumstances, and judged by which outcomes?

In 2016, I wrote an article called *Natural Births in the Age of Litigation*. I ended that article with an exhortation: keep calm and labour on. A decade later, I am not so sure.

Ruma Satwik is a Delhi-based gynaecologist. The views expressed are personal

Oil rises to 6-wk high after Houthi attack on Saudi sites

Reuters
letters@hindustantimes.com

LONDON: Oil prices rose to a six-week high on Tuesday after Iran-backed Houthis in Yemen attacked Saudi energy facilities, setting oil installations ablaze and threatening a major expansion of the six-month-old Middle East war.

Brent crude futures rose 70 cents, or 0.7%, to \$97.70 a barrel at 8:26pm (India time), while US West Texas Intermediate (WTI) crude rose \$1.21, or 1.3%, to \$92.69. That puts Brent on track for its highest close since July 23 and WTI on track for its highest close since June 4.

The Houthis attacked four cities in the south of US-ally Saudi Arabia on Tuesday, wounding more than 70 people. Houthi-controlled media reported later on Tuesday that Saudi warplanes had carried out four airstrikes in Yemen's Jubah district east of the capital Sanaa.

Oil exports from the Gulf region have been severely impaired since Iran attacked energy infrastructure in the region and ships passing through the Strait of Hormuz following joint strikes from the US and Israel in late February.

Saudi Arabia, the world's second-biggest crude producer behind the US, has been circumventing the strait by shipping oil west to the Red Sea. The attacks on Saudi Arabia, however, appear to be among the biggest carried out against that nation, and threaten to worsen the war's global economic effect by disrupting Middle East energy supplies beyond the blockaded Strait of Hormuz.

"The price action reflects both genuine physical tightness — tanker flows through Hormuz remain well below normal — and a clear geopolitical risk premium. Right now the risk premium is doing a lot of the heavy lifting," said Tim Waterer, chief market analyst at KCM Trade. Wall Street is also coming to grips with the likelihood that

SEIZED UNMANNED U.S. SUBMARINE DRONE IN HORMUZ: IRAN GUARDS

TEHRAN: Iran's Revolutionary Guards on Tuesday said they seized an American submarine drone in the strategic Strait of Hormuz, which Tehran has blockaded in the months-long Middle East war. "This smart submarine is equipped with the latest technology in the subsurface field in the world," the Guards said in a statement. **AFP**

Middle East shipping disruptions will continue into 2027. Goldman Sachs and HSBC raised their crude price forecasts for the rest of 2026 and 2027.

The number of commodity vessels sailing through the Strait of Hormuz totalled seven on Monday, compared with eight on the previous day, Kpler data showed on Tuesday.

Before the US and Israel attacked Iran in February, about 20% of world oil supplies passed through the Strait of Hormuz.

Global fuel prices remain high as well due to disruptions at refineries around the world, especially in the Middle East and Russia.

In the US, diesel prices reached record highs last week, and Americans faced record-high gasoline prices over the Labour Day holiday weekend.

Senior industry executives predicted global diesel supply will remain tight through winter due to a lack of spare refining capacity. Russia's ban on exports following attacks by Ukraine and the approach of peak winter demand.

In China, the world's second-biggest economy behind the US, crude oil imports in August improved from July, but volumes were down 23.4% from a year earlier, according to customs data released on Tuesday. China has restricted refined oil product exports since March to safeguard domestic supplies even as domestic consumption fell because of higher prices.



Trucks burn after a Houthi attack targeted vehicles coming from Saudi territory, at Al-Wadiah border crossing near Al-Wadiah, on the Saudi-Yemen border, on Monday. **REUTERS**

'UAE warned Israeli PM of major Hamas ops days before October 7 attack'

JERUSALEM: Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu was directly warned by the president of the United Arab Emirates that Hamas was planning a major offensive just days before the militant group attacked on October 7, 2023, according to an Israeli newspaper report.

UAE President Mohammed bin Zayed spoke with Netanyahu 10 days before the attack and said Yahya Sinwar, the leader of Hamas in Gaza at the time, was planning an operation, the Haaretz daily said.

Bin Zayed said it would lead to bloodshed and could destabilise the region and undermine the Abraham Accords, the normalisation agreements between Israel and several Arab and Muslim-majority nations, the newspaper reported.

But Netanyahu "reacted with relative calm", according to Haaretz, which said he assured bin Zayed that Israel was prepared for any scenario and a possible



Benjamin Netanyahu **REUTERS**

attack was more likely to come from the occupied West Bank.

Hamas militants killed some 1,200 people and took another 251 hostage in the October 7 attack. Hundreds of Israelis, mostly soldiers, have been killed in continued fighting from wars in Gaza, Lebanon and Iran.

Haaretz reported Netanyahu's office called the report an "absolute lie" and said Netanyahu did not speak with the UAE president "during the period in question and received no warning from him". **ASSOCIATED PRESS**

Kremlin: Trump told Putin he wants swift end to Ukraine war

Reuters & Associated Press
letters@hindustantimes.com

MOSCOW: US President Donald Trump told Russian President Vladimir Putin on Tuesday in a phone call that he wanted a swift end to the war in Ukraine, something that would allow US-Russia ties to be fully restored, the Kremlin said.

Kremlin aide Yuri Ushakov told reporters that the pair had discussed the outcome of a weekend visit to Moscow and Kyiv by US envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner — something he said both leaders had rated "with a plus sign" — and said that Putin had told Trump what he believed the United States could do to help end the conflict.

'Putin has no hostile plans towards Europe'
Ushakov said that Putin had given Trump his assessment of what the situation on the battlefield was and had made it clear



Donald Trump, Vladimir Putin

that Russia has no hostile plans towards Europe.

"Donald Trump clearly emphasised the desirability of bringing the conflict to an end as soon as possible, which would immediately open up prospects — impressive and far-reaching ones at that — for the full restoration of relations between the US and Russia," said Ushakov.

"In his view, this would have a particular impact on trade and economic ties, promising enormous benefits for both countries. Donald Trump is keen to see a breakthrough achieved during his presidency. Vladimir Putin supported this approach".

U.S. PREZ BACKS NEW H-1B FEE IN LABOUR DAY SPEECH

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump on Monday utilised his Labour Day speech to champion the proposed new levy on H-1B visa applications, asserting that the measure would incentivise domestic firms to prioritise hiring local workers before seeking personnel abroad.

"To ensure we are hiring and training American workers, we are proposing a new fee on H-1B visa petitions that will encourage companies to invest in qualified Americans before looking overseas for labour," Trump said.

The Department of Homeland Security is proposing a \$103,265 charge for cap-subject H-1B applications, encompassing those qualifying for advanced-degree exemptions, which would be collected upon filing alongside standard immigration costs to support administrative expenses. **ANI**

Tech glitch: Over 400 UK flights cancelled

LONDON: More than 400 flights were cancelled on Tuesday due to a technical issue in Britain's air traffic control system, the flight monitoring website Flightradar24 reported.

Britain's National Air Traffic Services said a problem had been identified in its flight processing system and engineers were urgently working on the issue, which affected flights across the UK.

In an update, it said it had "implemented a fix and our flight system is starting to recover".

About 425 flights to and from UK airports, including Heathrow, were cancelled, affecting services operated by multiple airlines, including British Airways, EasyJet, KLM and Lufthansa.

The affected airports, which

'Must be prepared for protracted conflict'

The world must be prepared for a protracted conflict between Russia and Ukraine, a senior Pentagon official said on Tuesday. "We must be prepared for a protracted conflict and for Ukraine's requirements to persist in the months and years ahead, and we must also be prepared for other plausible contingencies as well," Pentagon policy chief Elbridge Colby said at a videoconference of defence officials from countries supporting Ukraine.

Both countries resume their deadly air war

Both countries resumed their deadly air war after a weekend truce in their capitals for the American visitors. Russian attacks killed at least five civilians and wounded 25 others in Kyiv, officials said, while officials from Russia reported three people killed and 13 wounded from Ukrainian attacks.



Canada's 15-50% retaliatory tariffs against US in force

OTTAWA: Canada's retaliatory tariffs on US goods took effect just after midnight on Tuesday as PM Mark Carney increased economic pressure on his country's biggest trading partner after negotiations collapsed last month, intensifying an 18-month-old trade war. The counter-tariffs cover \$20 billion of U.S. goods, with duties ranging from 15% to 50% across products from steel and furniture to clothing and electronics. **REUTERS**

'Glacier experienced unprecedented heat before collapse'

PARIS: The mountain section whose collapse triggered fatal floods in Nepal and China on August 26 had experienced unprecedented heat for the time of year, meteorological data analysed by a researcher shows. Average temperatures on the mountain glacier at an altitude of 5,200 metres were estimated at around 5°C between August 21 and 26. They had not exceeded 4.0°C over the same period in more than 55 years of data recording. **AFP**

French police hunt for Renoir thieves after museum heist

CAGNES-SUR-MER: French police on Tuesday hunted for two thieves who escaped with two Renoir paintings from a museum, after abandoning two others as they fled, in a burglary that reignited concerns about the protection of France's cultural heritage. **AFP**

CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

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Banks look abroad to ease FCNR costs

Foreign debt gains appeal as banks explore refinancing

Subhana Shaikh

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MUMBAI: Indian banks are seeking longer-term overseas funding to replace short-term borrowings used during a rush to raise \$127 billion through the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) special FCNR(B) deposit scheme, according to five treasury officials. Several lenders turned to short-term borrowing to bridge the gap while arranging longer-term funding for FCNR(B) deposits, the officials said. They are now looking to replace those short-term liabilities with longer-term overseas borrowings, which would reduce their reliance on money-market funding as the existing borrowings come due.

Punjab National Bank, Bank of Baroda, Axis Bank, RBL Bank, Federal Bank, Canara Bank, Uco Bank, Bank of Maharashtra and IndusInd Bank are in early talks for potential overseas fundraising through the central bank's overseas foreign currency borrowing (OFCB) facility, according to people familiar with the matter. State-run power financier REC Ltd is also looking at a yen-denominated overseas bond, adding to what could be a sizable pipeline of foreign-currency fundraising in the coming months.

For banks, foreign-currency funding is becoming more attractive than raising equivalent longer-term funds domestically, particularly as they seek to refinance dollar-linked positions created during the FCNR(B) mobilization.

In simple terms, some banks borrowed money for a short period while putting the funds into longer-term loans or positions. As the short-term borrowings mature, the banks need to refinance them. Longer-term



RBI closed the special FCNR(B) window on 31 August. REUTERS

overseas funding offers a way to replace those liabilities and better match the duration of the assets they have financed.

Alongside its FCNR(B) announcement on June 5, the RBI also opened a swap facility for external commercial borrowings (ECBs) raised by public-sector companies and OFCBs raised by banks. Under the facility, banks can sell US dollars to RBI and agree to buy them back at the end of the swap period. Unlike the FCNR(B) scheme, under which the RBI bears the full hedging cost, the ECB/OFCB facility provides a 1.5% annual subsidy toward the cost of hedging foreign-currency funding. The cost of hedging OFCB exposure is generally about 3.5% to 4%, giving banks a benefit of roughly 200-250 bps on incremental OFCB borrowings.

"The OFCB route is a cheaper option relative to domestic borrowing. The fact that like the FCNR scheme, currency risk is taken on by the RBI adds to the attractiveness," Madan Sabnavis, chief economist at IDFC First Bank said.

When the scheme was announced on June 5, the yield gap between 10-year US Treasuries and their Indian counterparts was 245 basis points, compared with 218 basis points on Monday, Bloomberg data showed. The 10-year Indian government bond yield ended at 6.96% on Monday, compared with about 4.78% for

the US Treasury of similar maturity. The amounts have not been finalized, but market participants expect the aggregate fundraising to be substantial, two senior treasury officials said. Individual transactions could potentially be in the \$100-750 million range, although specific amounts remain under discussion. An email sent to the banks and non-banks listed above remained unanswered. Axis Bank declined to comment.

"My stronger argument for opting for OFCB would be the tenor, liability, stability, reduced roll-over risk and from funds raised via short-term market and the RBI's concessional swap economics," Venkatkrishnan Srinivasan, founder of Rockfort Fincap LLP said.

Banks mobilized a record \$127.22 billion through FCNR(B) deposits under the RBI's foreign-exchange swap facility before the central bank closed the window on 31 August, a month ahead of its original deadline. Together with \$5.26 billion raised through ECBs and \$3.89 billion through OFCBs, the facility attracted \$136.37 billion of inflows. The early closure of the FCNR(B) mobilization meant some banks did not have enough time to arrange matching long-term funding, according to treasury officials. Instead, they used shorter-term money-market borrowing as a temporary source of funds.

Satellite broadband cos to pay 5% of AGR as spectrum charge

Jatin Grover

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NEW DELHI: The department of telecommunications (DoT) has approved 5% of adjusted gross revenue (AGR) as the annual spectrum usage charge for satellite internet service providers such as Starlink, OneWeb and Jio Satellite, according to officials and industry executives aware of the development.

The companies, whose service rollout hinges on security clearance, are also expected to get a 1% discount for serving users in government-notified hard-to-connect areas, such as border towns, hills, and islands, the people added.

Far-flung areas to be notified would include places where satellite internet connectivity offers an advantage over traditional mobile networks, said a government official. The official said that on September 2, the Digital Communications Commission (DCC) discussed the recommendations by the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (Trai) on terms and conditions for the assignment of spectrum for certain satellite-based commercial communication services.

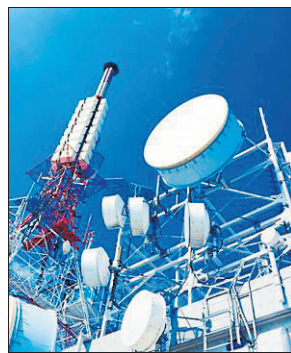
The spectrum will be allocated via a non-auction route for a period of five years, extendable by two years.

In May 2025, Trai mooted 4% of AGR, with a minimum of ₹3,500 per MHz, as annual minimum spectrum fee for firms offering both fixed and mobile satellite services.

The regulator also recommended an additional annual charge of ₹500 per subscriber for fixed satellite service providers in urban areas, so that the companies do not primarily target urban users because of their high-paying capacity.

At a meeting last September, the DCC approved an annual minimum spectrum charge of ₹3,500 per MHz, according to the DoT's FY26 annual report.

The DoT, however, rejected Trai's ₹500-per-subscriber charge for serving urban areas, believing a disincentive-led model could lead to implementation challenges, as it would have been difficult to differentiate between rural and urban areas. "The idea is that the incentives should be based on areas where LEO/MEO (low-earth orbit/medium-earth orbit) satellites work better than regular technologies, such as border



Satellite communication firms will also have to pay an annual licence fee of 8% AGR. ISTOCK

regions, hilly areas, and islands," said another official.

Mint's queries emailed to the DoT on Tuesday evening remained unanswered.

On 17 November, Mint first reported that the government wanted to levy 1% less AGR than the standard 5% if a certain percentage of satellite internet users served by the companies lived in hard-to-connect areas. The DoT had sought Trai's recommendations on the same at the time.

In its response in December, Trai said the rural-urban bifurcation is well established in the

regulatory framework, providing a reliable basis for policy implementation and compliance monitoring.

"Given the relatively higher purchasing power of subscribers in urban areas compared to rural areas and hence the high demand/consumption of data in these regions, it is possible that NGSO (non-geostationary satellite orbit)-based FSS (fixed satellite service) providers may focus more on urban areas. This could potentially undermine the goal of bridging digital divide in rural and remote areas," Trai had said.

It had added that a per-subscriber annual fee of ₹500 in urban areas, therefore, would give operators incentive to serve rural, remote areas.

As part of a back reference to Trai on satellite spectrum assignment, the DoT also rejected Trai proposal on the provision of a subsidy for each fixed satellite user terminal in the rural areas at an apt amount through a direct benefit transfer or Digital Bharat Nidhi (DBN) fund that aims to bridge urban-rural digital gap.

Satellite communication firms will also have to pay an annual licence fee of 8% AGR.

RIL PLANS \$1.3 BN BOND SALE; FIRST IN THREE YEARS

Bloomberg

feedback@livemint.com

Billionaire Mukesh Ambani's Reliance Industries Ltd. is planning to raise as much as \$1.3 billion via local-currency bonds as early as next week, according to people familiar with the matter, which would make it the largest listed deal in the market this year.

The company plans to raise the funds through AAA rated notes due in five years at a coupon of 7.47%, the people said, asking not to be identified as the details are private. The rate is much lower than the 7.87% average yield on top-rated five-year corporate bond ended on Monday.

The issuance, the conglomerate's first offering since November 2023, will likely provide a boost to local debt market after a slow start this year, as companies turned to bank loans to meet financing needs amid relatively lower borrowing rates. Reliance joins other Indian companies considering bond offerings amid expectations that the RBI may tighten monetary policy later this year as inflation risks mount. "Reliance rupee bond issue will set a benchmark for top-rated issuers," said Ajay Manglunia, executive director at Capri Global Capital Ltd.

Adani leads rush for ₹37,500 cr coal gasification plan

Rituraj Baruah

rituraj.baruah@livemint.com

NEW DELHI: Five companies have shown interest in the government's ₹37,500 crore coal gasification scheme, with Adani Enterprises Ltd submitting three separate applications for three projects and state-run NTPC Ltd and Talcher Fertilizers Ltd submitting one each.

Other applicants are Gallant Ispat Ltd and Shyam Sel & Power Ltd, according to a statement from the coal ministry. The second round of applications under the scheme opened on Tuesday.

"Seven applications in the

very first round, including from some of India's largest industrial houses and public sector undertakings, are a clear vote of confidence in the scheme and in India's coal gasification mission," said Alok Kumar Singh, advisor (projects), ministry of coal.

The applications will now undergo detailed evaluation under the scheme guidelines. Application windows will open every two months, the ministry said, adding that several prospective applicants are at advanced stages of project preparation and are expected to apply in subsequent rounds.

Coal and lignite gasification



The request for proposals was issued on 7 July. MINT

projects are large, capital-intensive investments that require pre-feasibility studies, technol-

ogy assessments, environmental considerations and financial planning, the ministry said.

The request for proposals was issued on 7 July.

The scheme, with an outlay of ₹37,500 crore, aims to set up 25 gasification plants over the next three to four years and reduce India's dependence on imported liquefied natural gas (LNG).

It is in addition to the ongoing ₹8,500-crore viability gap funding programme.

Under the scheme, financial incentives of up to 20% of plant and machinery costs will be provided to beneficiaries selected through competitive

bidding.

The government aims to promote the conversion of domestic coal and lignite into higher-value products such as syngas, methanol, ammonia, urea and hydrogen.

The synthetic gas produced through gasification can be used in fertiliser production, reducing natural gas imports.

Imports of LNG, urea, ammonia and methanol together stood at about ₹2.77 lakh crore in FY25.

The government aims to achieve 100 million tonnes of coal gasification capacity by 2030, including 75 million tonnes under the scheme.

ED CLOSES PROBE IN SIERRA LEONE, CHAD MONEY LAUNDERING CASE

Neeraj Chauhan

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: A decade after the Enforcement Directorate (ED) launched a money laundering probe into alleged irregularities in projects funded under the Government of India-supported Line of Credit (LoC) scheme in Sierra Leone and Chad, the agency has closed the case, finding no evidence to establish the allegations, according to officials who asked not to be named.

The probe involved a Noida-based project engineering, procurement and construction company, Angeliq International Limited (AIL), its managing director Ajay Krishna Goyal, director MP Gupta, and unidentified officials of the ministry of external affairs (MEA), Sierra Leone and Chad. It was alleged that kickbacks were paid to secure the contracts. Around the same time, the company also faced allegations of using "unfair means" to secure World Bank-financed projects.

Under India's development assistance programmes, the government extends concessional Lines of Credit or LoC through Exim Bank to developing countries for infrastructure and economic development. Projects are proposed by the beneficiary countries and processed by the Indian government under the applicable LoC guidelines.

In 2011 and 2012, respectively, two projects under the scheme were for a solar street-lighting project in Sierra Leone and a textile mill in Chad.

The Sierra Leone contract, valued at \$25.30 million, including a \$19.99 million LoC component, was signed in 2011. The Chad contract, valued at \$15.70 million, was signed in 2012.

It was alleged that illegal payments were made at both the pre-contract and post-contract stages, and that some transactions were routed through a Cyprus-based company.

However, investigations didn't reveal any fraudulent acts on the part of Indian authorities, said an officer, citing details of the probe.

The repayment of the funding amount to Exim Bank under the LoC scheme "is backed by the sovereign guarantee" of these two countries, a second officer said.

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

- Hot stew taken in by medical orderly (10)
- Member of a body (4)
- It is paid for what baby-minders do after six (5)
- Some repast eaten little by little (9)
- Con man? (8)
- Brother's daughter is said to be in French resort (5)
- Antipathy that is largely contrived (7)
- Given first-class fare (7)
- Understanding French (7)
- Rudolph's Canadian cousin? (7)
- We've a new way to make cloth (5)
- Request with certain satisfaction (8)
- There's a lot to be said for being this (9)
- Quick breathing (5)
- Arkwright's lack of response in the surgery? (4)
- The unusually stern needs of affection (10)

DOWN

- Touch and go (4)
- The first man to fly an aircraft (4,5)
- Dismissed by the party and overcome (5)
- Warrior unit yet to be disciplined for profanity (7)
- One helping a superior it's said (7)
- She'll show anger with heartless nurse (5)
- Its author must love to write it (6,4)
- He hasn't yet made a score (8)
- One keeps dry on it (5,5)
- He hoists a flag but not for the winner (6-2)
- Rake in and reel a bit carelessly (9)
- Go off in a bad temper? (7)
- Folded when credit was derestricted (7)
- Arterial way of vital importance (5)
- Steps look sound (5)
- Make sure head of finance goes over the charges (4)

YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17585)

CRYPTIC

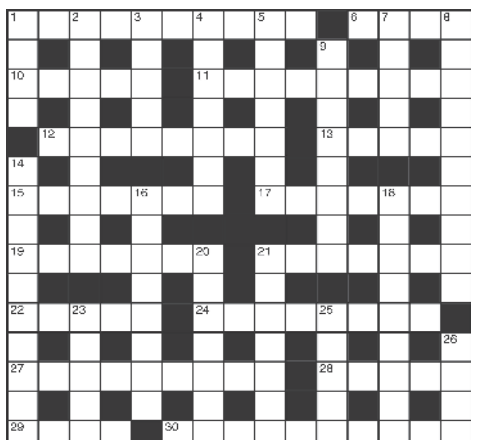
I	N	E	R	T	I	A		H	O	O	K	S
D	M	A	P	O		T	O					
E	A	S	I	C	H	A	I	R	H	A	L	
A		K		T	O	E	I					
L	O	O	T	C	H	O	L	E	R	I	C	
A	G	E	I	N	G		E	G	O	I	S	T
T	R	I	N	G	L		Y	S				
H	E	D	G	E	R	O						
E	D	G	E	R	V	A		A				
S	I	D	A		O	R	D	E	R	L	I	E
S		W	L	E		I						
T	I	E	N	E	T		D	R	A		W	E
S												

QUICK

C	R	A	C	K	U	P		M	O	T	I	F
R	C	E	R		A		E					
O	N	T	H	E	R	A	C	K		R	I	G
D	A	S	H		Q	U	A		G	M		
O	V	E	R	L		M	O		N			
M	D	A		A	P	O						
I	N	A	C	O	R	D						
N	D		K	O		S						
O	D		O	F	F	L		I	M	I	T	S
U	L		L	I		G		R		K		
S	I	C	E	N	T		T	A	N		N	E
R												

PUZZLE 17586

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QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

- Dull (10)
- Long narrow incision (4)
- Sudden convulsive movement (5)
- Extremely renowned performer (9)
- Very fashionable (3,3,2)
- Spy (5)
- External (7)
- Resounding deep rumbling (7)
- Strive (7)
- Profound (7)
- Fanatical (5)
- Beneficial (8)
- Adjudicate (9)
- Cover loosely with cloth (5)
- World's longest river (4)
- Very nearly (6,4)

DOWN

- Endure (4)
- A quack (9)
- Greatest permissible amount (5)
- Temporarily debar from office (7)
- Sympathetic relationship (7)
- Machine used for turnery (5)
- Capsize (4,6)
- Government finance department (8)
- Without doubt (3,7)
- Short account of incident (8)
- Define boundaries of (9)
- Be without hope (7)
- Minor illness (7)
- Confused sound of voices (5)
- Modern times (5)
- Have marked effect (4)

{ SUDOKU }

DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★★★★



Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9x9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.



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{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE ■ HIGH ■ LOW



WEDNESDAY
Generally cloudy
sky with light rain

31°C | 21°C



THURSDAY
Generally cloudy
sky with light rain

31°C | 20°C



FRIDAY
Generally cloudy
sky with light rain

30°C | 20°C

ALMANAC

Today is 9th September 2026

• 26 Rabi ul Awwal, 1448

• 13 Bhadrapada, Krishna Paksha, 13

• Samvat 2083

• Sunset: Wednesday at 06:25 p.m.

• Sunrise: Thursday at 06:08 a.m.

• Moonset: Wednesday at 05:08 p.m.

• Moonrise: Thursday at 05:11 a.m.

TEMPERATURE IN METROS

Delhi 35°C | 26°C

Mumbai 33°C | 26°C

Kolkata 32°C | 26°C

Chennai 37°C | 27°C

Bengaluru 31°C | 21°C

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



Volodar Murzin: Former chess champion still waiting to arrive

Russia's 2024 world rapid champion talks about chess, plans to switch federations and an abusive dad

Susan Ninan
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BENGALURU: There is perhaps something a bit strange about already having become a world champion and still being treated like a boy who might one day arrive.

Volodar Murzin knows the feeling. He won the World Rapid Championship in 2024, ahead of top players like Fabiano Caruana, Hikaru Nakamura and Jan-Krzysztof Duda. At 18, he was the second youngest to do so. The title brought invitations, confidence and the comforting knowledge that stronger players could no longer intimidate him quite so easily. "I started to trust myself more."

The boy-who-might-one-day-arrive label though remains. It's his third successive year at the Tech Mahindra Global Chess League on the Prodigy board. He's with the Alpine APL Pipers side, which has Magnus Carlsen as its Icon player.

Perhaps ratings are partly to blame. Murzin is around 2650 in classical chess, not yet among the game's elite, and he knows what that means in a chess world increasingly crowded with teenagers who arrive with extraordinary ratings attached to their names. "I'm not worse than those on the Superstars team (in the GCL) because I have higher ratings than some of them," he says, smiling. "I hope it will change soon."

There is no angst in the way he says it. His targets are

Russian on the rise

VOLODAR MURZIN
Born: Jul 18, 2006 (age 20)
Country: Russia
Ranking 56

RATING
2656 **2620** **2670**
Classical Rapid Blitz

		Games	Won	Drew	Lost
Classical	With White	588	287	228	73
	With Black	587	219	247	121
Rapid	With White	388	197	103	88
	With Black	388	186	112	90
Blitz	With White	433	230	99	104
	With Black	432	216	80	136

In December 2024, Murzin won the World Rapid Championship with a score of 10/13, following it with a tie for fifth in the World Blitz Championship.

"I remember sitting at the computer and playing. He made me play. Till four. Sometimes five. I was tired. Very tired. I had school in a few hours. He was angry, wanted to punish me" — VOLODAR MURZIN



straightforward, even if not easy—2700, the top 10, eventually the classical World Championship. He is dealing with more pressing challenges, however, like not being able to get visa clearance or play many tournaments, since his Russian nationality is an obstacle.

"I want to change my federation. I have no contact with the Russian federation and receive no support from them." He has reached out to other national federations, he says. "Right now, I can't play Bundesliga.

Some other tournaments too. If I change federation, I can play more tournaments in Europe."

Murzin grew up in the shadow of an abusive father. Chess was both a gift and a torment. His father called it the "devil's game" and stopped him from travelling to tournaments for two years. "I lost lot of time. It was huge damage."

This was around the time he was chasing his third and final grandmaster norm. He occasionally searches for the right English words to convey his

thoughts, and the memories arrive in staccato phrases. It makes what he endured feel like a punch to the gut.

"I remember sitting at the computer and playing. He made me play. Till four. Sometimes five. I was tired. Very tired. I had school in a few hours. He was angry, wanted to punish me."

Assault was the norm in the household. Murzin and his four sisters would have raw eggs smashed on their heads by their father. If he objected, his head could be slammed against the

wall. His father once hit his older sister with a shovel.

Chess arrived as a saviour when he was 11. His victory in the U-12 European Youth Championship led to an invitation from Sergey Nesterov's Prof Chess Club in Khimki. His mother, Ekaterina, saw this as an opportunity to save her children. She left their home in Nizhny Tagil and took him and his sisters along, travelling more than 1,700 km to Khimki.

Abusive fathers, Murzin says, aren't uncommon in Russia. "I

know friends who have gone through similar experiences. But they don't tell anyone since they feel it won't change anything. They still live with their fathers."

"But my mother ran away," he says in appreciation of her courage. "I want to forget that he exists in my life. I want to remove him formally as my father. I don't think it can be done in Russia. We are free now. But I don't know what troubles he can cause us in the future."

SC seeks response of BCCI, state units on 2025 Sports Act

Abraham Thomas
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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday sought the response of the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) and state cricket bodies to bring them under the National Sports Governance Act 2025. The order was passed by a bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant which is hearing applications with regard to implementation of the BCCI Constitution by state bodies.

The bench, also comprising justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana said, "All cricket associations in the country are directed to take instructions on why the conditions of service of selected office bearers be not governed by the National Sports Governance Act 2025."

The order was passed as the court took up an application filed by the Baroda Cricket Association represented by senior advocate S Muralidhar who sought clarification on the tenure of office-bearers in the state association.

The court asked Muralidhar, "Now the new Act has come. Why should it not apply to you." Muralidhar told the court that BCCI should make its stand clear in this regard. BCCI is a private association registered under the TN Societies Registration Act, 1975 and is not governed by any statute even as it controls the game of cricket in India. The proceedings before the top court arose out of an appeal filed by BCCI challenging an order of the Bombay high court in relation to the spot fixing allegations during the 2013 IPL.

In 2015, the top court directed a committee headed by former CJI RM Lodha to propose structural reforms in the functioning of BCCI in the interest of transparent working of the body. He submitted his report in February 2016 suggesting wide ranging reforms on cooling-off period, fixed tenure, conflict of interest, and grounds for disqualification for a candidate

THE ORDER WAS PASSED AS THE COURT TOOK UP AN APPLICATION FILED BY BARODA UNIT SEEKING CLARIFICATION ON THE TENURE OF OFFICE-BEARERS

to contest elections in BCCI or its state units.

Based on the Justice Lodha committee recommendations, the court appointed a committee of administrators to implement the reforms. In August 2018, the court approved the draft constitution by the CoA. The sweeping reforms under the proposed Constitution brought a radical shift in the functioning of BCCI and state units. These reforms introduced a cooling-off period after two successive terms for office-bearers in BCCI or state bodies, and prescribed an age cap of 70, among other changes.

Incidentally, in January, the top court had refused to entertain a petition challenging the team selected by BCCI to be called "Team India". The petition had argued that BCCI is a private association and not a National Sports Federation (NSF) recognised under the National Sports Development Code of India, 2011.

It cited clauses 3.6, 3.7, and 9.3 of the Sports Code of India, 2011, which authorises only recognised NSFs to use the word "India" in their name, select teams to represent India at international forums, and receive governmental recognition and financial assistance.

The last election of BCCI office-bearers was held in September last year when Mithun Manhas was elected president and Devajit Salkia secretary for a three-year term. As per the BCCI constitution, office-bearers can have a maximum of two consecutive terms which must be followed by a cooling-off period of three years.

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Gauff powers ahead, with a tweaked serve and forehand

The 2023 champion and world No.4 is buoyant after reaching the US Open quarter-finals

Shahid Judge

shahid.judge@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: On match point, Coco Gauff tried something different. The 22-year-old American is a defensive baseliner who clings to the back of the court to build points. Now, when she was a point away from a spot in the last eight of a Grand Slam, she decided to serve-and-volley for the first time in the match.

"I was thinking when I hit the serve that I'm either going to love this or regret this," she said in the post-match press conference. "I don't know if it shows how confident I am, or just the ideas in my head that pop up on match point."

It was probably one of those drastic ideas that comes up only when a player is hitting the ball sweetly, moving around the court with ease, pulling off moves she tends not to use, and is playing with a great deal of confidence. It all showed on Monday night at the Arthur Ashe Stadium when fourth seed Gauff beat budding star and compatriot Iva Jovic 6-1, 6-4 to reach the quarter-final of the US Open.

The straight-set result came in a match that lasted an hour and 33 minutes, but it was a statement win for the 2023 champion. And this for a player who, in the fourth round in New York last year, told her player box that "nothing's working" as she slumped to a straight sets defeat against Naomi Osaka.

Gauff is a different player from last year, despite the fact that she had won the French Open in 2025—her second Grand Slam title. Last season, she struggled for consistency on her serve and the forehand had become a clear chink in the armour.

This year, there has been improvement in the performance of her reworked serve, and on Monday, her forehand was a weapon.

"Just trying to have better footwork on that shot has made a difference," she explained. "It's just knowing that in practice I've been executing it well, and I've started to execute it really well in matches. Honestly, I feel like when you have a weakness, and over the years everybody just starts hitting to it, you have no choice but getting better. So, I welcome it. I feel like every match I'm hitting more forehands than backhands, so it's getting better."

Along with her forehand

though, her overall performances have also been on the upswing. The win against Jovic took her win streak to 10 matches, and she has won 20 sets on the trot. The run includes the Cincinnati Masters title, won a week before the US Open.

Beating Jovic also means that she has reached a Grand Slam quarter-final for the 12th time. Only Serena Williams (15) and Maria Sharapova (13) did better before turning 23, since 2000.

That's an enviable statistic. But the one that would matter more for Gauff is the possibility that she could become world No.1 if she wins the US Open—provided Elena Rybakina, now in the quarters, does not reach the semis.

"A quarter-final for me, I feel like I'm at the point where I'm used to being in this position," she said. "I'm constantly putting myself in quarter-finals, so the moment doesn't seem as big anymore."

Like most players though, she tends to take it one match at a time. And the match against Jovic started with Gauff losing serve in the very first game.

Gauff though is probably one of the most dangerous players on tour when on the backfoot. In fact, in both the Grand Slam titles she won—2023 US Open and 2025 Roland Garros—she had lost the first set in the final.

She used that early setback to fuel a solid recovery that saw her win the next six games to seal the first set. The second saw a bit more fight from the tenacious Jovic, who would not go away despite Gauff getting the first break of the set.

The world No.4 though proved her class and experience in breaking her opponent's serve at love to go up 5-4, and then served out the match to complete a confident performance. And Gauff herself knows she is in good form.

"Just my nervous system and knowing that when the pressure is there, I'm able to rely on a lot of different things to win points in different ways. That gives me confidence, knowing that I have, probably up to this point, a Plan D," she said.

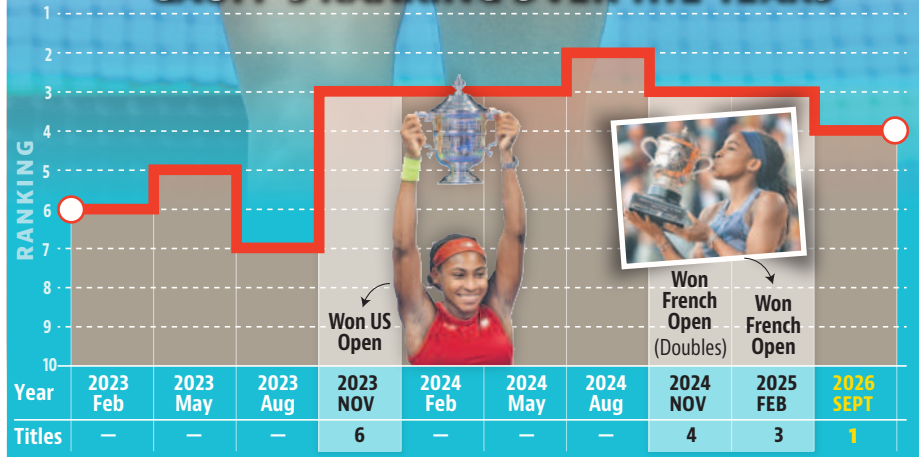
"There's comfort in knowing that if Plan A isn't working, then there's B, C, D. And I think that's something that makes me comfortable. The biggest difference is that I've been trying to play with no regrets. I've had a lot more fun and success playing like this."

Up next for Gauff is another teenager—19-year-old Mirra Andreeva who won the 2026 French Open. Gauff, though, has a 5-0 record against the Russian. It's just another statistic to top up the confidence the American is brimming with.



Coco Gauff of the US after beating compatriot Iva Jovic at the US Open. REUTERS

GAUFF'S RANKING OVER THE YEARS



KEY RESULTS: FOURTH ROUND

MEN

Alexander Zverev (GER x1) bt Luciano Darderi (ITA) 6-2, 6-2, 7-6 (7/3); **Botic van de Zandschulp** (NED) bt Arthur Gea (FRA) 3-6, 6-7 (0/7), 7-6 (9/7), 7-6 (7/3), 6-4; **Karen Khachanov** (RUS) bt Learner Tien (USA x14) 7-5, 4-6, 6-7 (6/8), 6-1, 6-4; **Alexander Blockx** (BEL x28) bt Francisco Cerundolo (ARG x24) 6-3, 4-6, 7-5, 7-5

WOMEN

Coco Gauff (USA x4) bt Iva Jovic (USA x14) 6-1, 6-4; **Elena Rybakina** (KAZ x2) bt Naomi Osaka (JPN x13) 6-1, 6-4; **Aryna Sabalenka** (BLR x1) bt Linda Noskova (CZE x6) 7-6 (1), 3-6, 7-6 (7)

Mind the age gap: Shami, Vaibhav bowl in tandem

HT Correspondent

sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

KOLKATA: For a stretch of five overs on Tuesday afternoon, something surreal unfolded at the Chepauk stadium.

From one end bowled Mohammed Shami, 36 and still capable of making a cricket ball behave in ways batters would rather it did not. From the other end was Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, 15 and whose cricket education is still in its earliest chapters. For five overs either side of tea on Day 3, the veteran and the prodigy bowled in tandem, a 21-year age gap compressed into the same spell of a Duleep Trophy final.

Not just unusual, this was a pairing rarely seen in cricket at any stage. In 1990, a 17-year-old Sachin Tendulkar had first bowled in an ODI at Nottingham, with Kapil Dev, then 31, the most senior bowler in the attack. That was a 14-year gap between India's youngest and oldest bowlers. At Chepauk, the gulf was seven years wider.

There was an appealing simplicity to the picture. Shami, with the accumulated knowledge of hundreds of matches, seemed to be conducting an examination. Sooryavanshi, having just begun writing his own cricketing history, quietly slipped in some overs to force the struggling South Zone to think outside the box.

Those three overs cost Sooryavanshi only eight runs. Shami's experience was more obvious in the numbers at the end of the day—11 overs, four maidens, 17 runs and two wickets. Yet, the significance of the five overs they shared was not measured by economy rates. It was a glimpse of cricket's continuum, with one



Mohammed Shami. PTI

generation passing through the same contest as another begins to make its mark.

They could also afford it, given how East Zone have placed themselves in this match. Having amassed a colossal 708, they spent the next phase of the game steadily dismantling South Zone's response. South reached 242/6 at stumps, still 466 runs behind. The wickets did not arrive in a dramatic cluster. Instead, East Zone applied pressure patiently, allowing South's batsmen to make the mistakes.

Opener Narayan Jagadeesan's dismissal was the first clear example. Having made 32, he reached away from his body facing Shikhar Mohan's left-arm spin and sliced the ball to backward point. Mohan had only been introduced because all-rounder Anukul Roy, who also bowls left-arm spin, was off the

field with a finger injury. This unexpected opportunity produced Mohan's maiden first-class wicket.

Devdutt Padikkal, after making 62 from 104 balls, followed in an even more frustrating fashion. A perfectly respectable delivery from Mukesh Kumar was flicked majestically — and straight to deep square leg. Padikkal knew immediately what he had done, and walked away with a wry smile and a hand on his helmet.

Shami had in the previous over produced the breakthrough that helped turn pressure into authority. The young Shaik Rasheed (27) had added 56 runs with Padikkal when he was trapped leg before by one that nipped back at 134.8kph. Shami later returned for a short spell and removed Ravichandran Smaran with an excellent delivery that induced a thin edge. Kumar Kushagra persistently urging a review of the original not-out decision proved decisive.

Mukesh had foxed Padikkal by taking the pace off to force him to mistime for his second wicket while Shami's spell demonstrated that the ball could still reverse after 35-odd overs, something Rasheed discovered to his dismay. Skipper Tilak Varma remained unbeaten on 56, but South's batting has been punctuated by starts wasted. With East's total still in the distance, South will require something extraordinary simply to make the final even remotely competitive.

Brief scores: East Zone 1st innings 708. South Zone 1st innings 242/6 in 80 overs (D Padikkal 62, T Varma 56*, N Jagadeesan 32; M Shami 2/17, M Kumar 2/36).

India's Asiad squad gets warm send-off



The Indian contingent poses for photographs with sports minister Mansukh Mandaviya during the send-off ceremony for the 2026 Asian Games, in New Delhi on Tuesday. SANJEEV VERMA/HT

India-Japan T20I: A massive hit off the field

Rasesh Mandani

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MUMBAI: The unlikelyst of sporting faceoffs—India and Japan on a cricket pitch—is getting a huge cheer from the market with broadcast rights—both TV and digital bagged by Star Sports and Fan-Code respectively for impressive valuation.

Leading global streaming players Netflix, Amazon, YouTube and DAZN have shown interest in picking up global rights for the landmark fixture to be played at Sano International cricket ground in Tochigi. When these bids are opened in a day, there is anticipation of record broadcast revenue generation from a single T20I.

Also, prospects of live cricket landing for the first time on Netflix is being followed with much interest.

On the face of it, the one-off T20I on September 22 is a mismatch of epic proportions with world champions India taking on 41st ranked Japan. The match which leads up to the Asian Games doesn't even enjoy a prime time viewing pitch in India with a scheduled Tuesday 9.30am start.

The difference comes in the setting. This isn't a random T20I adding to the clutter in the international cricket calendar. The unique positioning of the fixture, being part of the flagship Sport 75 initiative—the match celebrates 75 years of diplomatic relations between the two nations—is

COOL SABALENKA EDGES PAST NOSKOVA IN THREE SETS TO ENTER SEMI-FINAL

Associated Press

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NEW YORK: Aryna Sabalenka kept alive her hopes for a third straight US Open championship by fighting off Linda Noskova 7-6 (1), 3-6, 7-6 (10-7) on Tuesday in a thrilling quarter-final matchup of Major championships.

Sabalenka finished off the match with a second-serve ace to turn back the Wimbledon champion and reach the semi-finals in Flushing Meadows for the sixth straight year.

Sabalenka—who needed to win to maintain the No.1 ranking—will face either No.3 Jessica Pegula or No.26 Emma Navarro on Thursday in the semifinals.

Noskova, the No.6 seed, won her first major title at the All England Club and narrowly missed becoming the first woman since Serena Williams in 2016 to follow a title on the grass by reaching the final four on the hardcourts of New York.

Meanwhile, Elena Rybakina is one win away from the world number one ranking, but the Kazakh star says her main goal in her US Open quarter-final clash with Zheng Qinwen on Wednesday is to advance toward a third Grand Slam title.

"Number one ranking is, of course, one of the goals," Rybakina says. "But I think the main focus for me is to win the titles, and then the ranking will follow up."

Rybakina arrived at Flushing Meadows as one of four women with a chance to supplant Aryna Sabalenka atop the rankings, and the only one with her fate in her own hands.

Reaching the semi-finals will send her to the summit for the first time, and she could even get there if she loses—if current world number three Jessica Pegula and fourth-ranked Coco Gauff all fail to lift the trophy.

Rybakina, who has shown no sign of the foot injury that hindered her US Open preparations, will be out to halt the remarkable run of Zheng—the Paris Olympics gold medalist who had to come through qualifying thanks to a rankings plunge in the wake of elbow surgery last year.

Gauff, in the quarters for the first time since she won the US Open title in 2023, will take on fifth-seeded French Open champion Mirra Andreeva for a place in the semis while men's top seed Alexander Zverev faces Dutch veteran Botic van de Zandschulp.

Alexander Blockx tries to further his dream US Open debut taking on Russian Karen Khachanov.

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

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Sky blue, saffron jerseys for Indian hockey at Asiad

Sandip Sikdar

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NEW DELHI: Following the furore over choosing saffron coloured jerseys instead of the traditional blue at the World Cup last month, the Indian hockey teams will wear blue once again at the Asian Games, which will be held in Japan from September 19 to October 4. However, this doesn't mean the saffron jersey has been dumped.

The Indian men's and women's teams will, like always, have two jerseys. One will be a mix of white and sky blue, the other will be saffron. "The white on sky blue jersey is similar to what we wore at the last Asian Games in Hangzhou (in 2023)," an India player told HT before boarding the flight to Japan on Tuesday.

While Hockey India (HI) decides India's colours at bilateral or international hockey federation (FIH) events such as the World Cup, the Indian Olympic Association (IOA) decides the colours at multi-sport events such as the Olympics, Asian Games and Commonwealth Games.

"The IOA had given us options regarding the team kit colours and HI selected blue as the first choice for the Indian team's kit. Orange will be the second choice," HI president Dilip Tirkey said on the sidelines of the Asian Games squad send-off.

"It is the IOA's prerogative. They certainly check with the National Sports Federation (NSF) as all NSFs and sports have different specifications and requirements," an HI official told HT on condition of anonymity.

After consulting the respective NSFs about the kind of jerseys required for training or

matches depending on the nature of the sport, IOA takes the decision in consultation with fashion designers.

It is important to understand that the ceremonial and travel jerseys—chosen by IOA alone—are different from training and match jerseys.

At the World Cup, the Indian teams had completely dumped the iconic blue jersey in favour of saffron with white being the second option. Hockey teams generally have two colours for competitions. One option has always been blue for India while the other has changed from white to yellow to saffron over the years.

"The FIH director of the tournament decides which team will wear which colour on a particular matchday. Say for example, if China play in red, then India will not wear saffron because the colours are similar. In that case, India will wear white on sky blue," another HI official told HT.

HI faced immense angst for choosing saffron over the traditional blue at the World Cup with many former skippers saying it diluted the identity of the teams. HI's rationale was that the blue jersey caused visibility issues on the blue turf, a justification that didn't go down well with the greats of the game.

The controversy also exposed rifts within HI with president Dilip Tirkey questioning the move, stating that it was implemented without the executive board's approval. It also took a political turn, with opposition leaders targeting the government over the issue.

While the Indian men's team finished a disappointing eighth at the World Cup, the Salima Tete-led women ended fifth, their best show since the inaugural edition in 1974 when they finished fourth.

CA for privatisation in Big Bash League

Press Trust of India

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MELBOURNE: Cricket Australia approved private investment in its flagship T20 event, the Big Bash League, clearing the decks for Melbourne Renegades sale in full even though the country's players' body said "significant issues remain unresolved" in the new plan. CA announced that it would invite bids from private owners for a 100% stake in Melbourne Renegades.

The new ownership in the franchise will be in place for the 2027-28 Big Bash League and Women's Big Bash League seasons, and the sale process will have no impact on the upcoming seasons of the BBL and the WBBL this Australian summer, reported cricket.com.au.

The Renegades is being run in a caretaker mode by CA. Hobart

Hurricanes, Perth Scorchers and Melbourne Stars are the other clubs believed to be interested in private investment.

But others such as Sydney Sixers, Sydney Thunder, Brisbane Heat, and Adelaide Strikers, are not interested in private investment. CA chairman Mike Baird said the governing body will continue to have control over international scheduling, availability of the players, salary caps as well as media rights. While CA will retain power to approve or veto investors and set reserve price, any changes to club names, colours and branding would need approvals. In case of Renegades, CA will be the approving party while for other teams, the same would be the relevant state body. "By opening the door to private investment in BBL, CA is taking a step to strengthen and secure the long-term future of the game," Baird added.

India announced its bouquet of Associate Partners—Campa, SBI Life and ChatGPT for the upcoming home season of international cricket starting with the ODI series against West Indies and running until March 2028.

While the combined deal amounting to over ₹130 crore, represents a 44% increase over the previous cycle, BCCI's inability to secure a title sponsor reflects the market's poor estimation of Indian cricket's bilateral calendar.

The BCCI had increased the asking price for title rights by 15.5%—₹4.85 crore from ₹4.2 crore per match—upon the expiry of the IDFC First Bank contract.

No title sponsor

Board of Control for Cricket in